

Block

4**MEDIA – SOCIETY THEORIES**

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BLOCK INTRODUCTION: MEDIA- SOCIETY THEORIES

This is the Fourth and final block of the Course **MDC-006: Media and Communication Theories**. There are four units in this block and each unit addresses major theoretical concepts related by broad Media and Society perspective.

Unit 13: Technological Determinism deals with social significance of media technologies as technology influences human communication. The knowledge gained is useful in application of technology determinism in your personal communication. In the age of ICT and information era this unit becomes very handy as you can reflect on how technology controls and shapes human behaviour.

Unit 14: Media and the Public Sphere is one of the core areas in today's journalism and mass communication as it discusses the relationship between media and the public sphere. You can participate in debates and discussions on issues of political consequence as explained in this unit. It is an exciting intellectual journey that every student of mass communication should undertake as it is a training ground to become a political analyst and media critic.

Unit 15: Audience Theories deals with one of the end users of media, the audience. You will understand the importance of feedback from audience and its importance in the functioning of media as the media industry is dictated by advertisers and programme ratings. You will be equipped to take up many opportunities to apply audience theories in your own research work.

Unit 16: Feminist Media Theories is crucial for the broad review of mass communication as it deals with the concept of gendering media. Any media professional should have roots in gender studies to do justice to the content produced by media. It sharpens your analytical skills and you get a forum for dialogue, discussions, and debates on analysing how media manifest gender biases in production, distribution, and audience reception.

It is advisable to study the units in a sequence as each unit is linked to subsequent units through common narrative on media and society. This block prepares you to become a good media professional or an academician with scholarly discourse on media and politics, media and technology, media and audience, and media and women. We hope that you will enjoy studying this Block and develop a good understanding of the concepts and perspectives discussed.

UNIT 13 TECHNOLOGICAL DETERMINISM

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13.1 INTRODUCTION

Humanity has passed through different kinds of societies. The earliest society was that of the hunter-gatherer. When man discovered how to grow his own food, the era of the Agricultural/Agrarian Society began. As civilisation progressed and man's needs grew, he invented machines and stepped into the Industrial Society. The Post-Industrial Society with its demands for national, international and global communication, information, transaction and interaction, ushered in the Information society. Today, urban life is a technological-informational life, and therefore, as societies developed with advances in industrialisation, the premise that technology changes people became important.

Technologies that have permeated our daily living significantly influence the way we understand our lives. The popularity and potential of the Internet and other new media has resulted in a refocus on two important theories on the

interplay of technology and society: Technological Determinism and its opposing school of thought, the Social Shaping of Technology.

This unit aims to provide a broader perspective on the variables and constructs that play a significant role in the evolution of societies, cultures and civilisations, in short, the evolution of humankind. It aims to explore questions - do technologies make us what we are or do we make technologies what they are? Is it as simple as that? In this unit, we shall discuss various aspects related to this theory – we shall start with the key elements such as society, culture and technology. Then we will introduce the initial debates and examine the core concepts of the theory. We shall also analyse some related as well as opposing theories to help you understand the finer nuances of Technological Determinism theory.

13.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the role of media technology in society and culture;
- describe the implications of Communication Technology Determinism;
- analyse the role of communication and other technologies in shaping the society; and
- apply Technological Determinism theory and TAM model in your research work.

13.3 KEY ELEMENTS AND THEIR RELATIONSHIPS

Technology, society, and culture have evolved over the ages side-by-side. They do not exist as parallel developments, but are seen as constructs that have an influence over each other. The relationship they share is dynamic, continuously changing, and growing at times mutually beneficial, at times not. Let us examine the relationship between technology and society and technology and culture. The focus here is also on communication technology.

13.3.1 Technology and Society

It is interesting to note that the history of human civilisation is characterised or named after the most important technology of that period. Roughly shaped pieces of stones, probably used as tools, are the earliest evidences of the presence of humans on earth (H.G.Wells, 2004 ed.). These stone implements became sharper and better chiseled as man evolved over the ages, from the earliest ages to the Neanderthal man and the Reindeer Age, when humans in the primitive form existed. Neolithic stage or the new Stone Age, is characterised by the primitive technology used- polished stone tools; especially the stone axe, and arrow heads made of flint. Man was still predominantly a hunter, though agriculture did happen to a small degree. Civilisations were thus named after the most important tools used by man: the Stone Age to the Bronze Age to the later Iron Age.

The agricultural age is again characterised by the primary technology that helped man to grow food, to settle down, and develop. Villages gave way to towns, and the Industrial revolution ushered in the cities with their factories, automobiles

and media. Today is the age of information technologies. So profound has been the impact of new media digital technologies on our society and our lives, that the age we live in now is labelled the Information Age.

Society refers to “people who interact in a defined territory and share a culture” (Macionis, 2005). In our understanding of technological determinism, Gerhard Lenski is important to us as he focuses on the role of technology in shaping society. He uses the comprehensive term *sociocultural evolution* to describe the “phenomena of societies that change with the acquisition of new technologies” (Lenski).

13.3.2 Technology and Culture

So, what is technology? The Collins Dictionary defines technology as referring to those “methods, systems, and devices which are the result of scientific knowledge being used for practical purposes”. The dictionary also defines the noun technologies as “the system by which a society provides its members with those things needed or desired” .

Culture is “the values, beliefs, behaviour; and material objects that together form a people’s way of life” (Macionis, 2005). It may be Nonmaterial (ideas/symbols/language/values) or it may be Material (tangible, made of things created by people; artifacts and technologies). Culture is continuous, a way of life passed on from one generation to another.

Technology is known to help people to lead more efficient lives; more advanced technologies indicate advanced societies, capable of leading ‘better’ lives. But it has a downside to it, too. It may be used for the ‘wrong’ reasons, and can be used as tools of the elite, depriving ordinary people of opportunities to benefit from it (Macionis, 2005).

While the industrial age had a direct impact on society/civilisation, the digital media technologies of the post-industrial age were so versatile that they created an information revolution, resulting in the Information age. New media technology has had a revolutionary impact on culture - in the way people communicate, network, buy, sell, spend their free time, work, live.

13.3.3 Media, Technology and Popular Culture

You have read in the previous units that research in media went through various phases. The early mass society theories were followed by the limited effects theories. Cultural theories focused on influence of media on the cultural life of individuals; these theories were microscopic and interpretive. Political Economy theories were macroscopic in nature. These theories criticised the elites for exploiting media to maintain their power and status (Baran and Davis, 2000).

The media are an integral part of people’s lives and dominate social actions; being increasingly demanding people’s attention. Media may be studied from three perspectives: as technologies, as institutions and as cultural forms that need to be structured and their meanings codified (Grossberg, 2006).

Popular culture refers to that aspect of the society that is part of everyday life, and is pervasive. It is mass produced and mass consumed, and heavily influenced by mass media; it is the mass media that provides the chief cultural experience

to people, shaping opinions and attitudes. Due to technological innovations, contemporary culture is characterised and influenced by rapidly changing technologies, especially information technologies (Andersen and Taylor, 2007). Macionis defines popular culture as those “cultural patterns that are widespread among a society’s population” (Macionis, 2005). High culture on the other hand, is one that is promoted by the elites. Popular culture addresses a large, heterogenous audience or people, and the source of popular culture is irrelevant. Mass media gave rise to media culture, and resulted in a new way of looking at popular culture. Popular culture today is an expression of a postmodern society where Information technology has not just influenced culture, it has created a new popular culture, that of the virtual world.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit

1) Define technology.

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2) Differentiate between civilisation, society and culture.

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3) What is the relationship between media and culture?

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13.4 INITIAL DEBATES

Any discussion on technological determinism has to begin with Harold Innis and Marshall McLuhan, both from the Toronto School of Communication. They sparked the early debates on technology and its significant influence on society and culture. For a student of communication, understanding their role in this school is crucial, since they both believed in the bigger role of communication and media technologies in deciding the key features of society.

13.4.1 Marshall McLuhan

During the 1960s, McLuhan’s analysis of the influence of the ‘electric media’ as he called them, drew attention all over the world. Unlike the limited effects theorists of the day, he focused on the role of electronic media on culture, and gave the microscopic critical theory a macroscopic dimension. Marshall McLuhan scrutinised the media from a fresh perspective, accepting the changes that it

brought about. He proposed that technology causes changes in social structures, thought, and culture and was therefore considered a *technological determinist* (Baran and Davis, 2000).

Technological Determinism can be seen as “an approach that identifies technology, or technological advances, as the central causal element in the processes of social change” (Croteau and Hoynes, 2000). Technological Determinism is a theory first proposed by American sociologist, Thorstein Veblen, that illustrates interlink between technology and society. It means technology is the cornerstone of change in the society influencing cultural, political and economic aspects and causes change in the society.

13.4.2 Harold Innis and Theory of Media Bias

McLuhan was heavily influenced by Harold Innis, a political economist and founder of the Toronto School of thought about the media. Innis made several assumptions about the relationship between the communication media and predominant social structures that existed at different points in history. In his *Empire and Communications* (1950), he pointed out that the ancient Egyptian, Greek and Roman empires were characterised by the control of the written word by the elites. He gave as evidence the role of papyrus in Egypt in giving power to those who could write the priests; and the record-keeping, bureaucratic tradition of the Roman Empire, which helped administer distant provinces. Printing technology, in turn, reduced bureaucratic power and helped the growth of individualism and nationalism (McQuail, 2010). Telephone and telegraph were further used by the elite to gain more effective control, over large areas.

Innis therefore, held the belief that the development of communication technologies resulted in greater centralisation of power. Because of this ‘bias of communication’ as he calls it in his book *Bias of Communication* (1951), the elites at the center exploited people and resources at the periphery or outlying areas (Baran and Davis, 2000). Bias of communication can be understood as the tendency of media to lean towards one particular kind of mediation. H.M. Innis of the Toronto School is the most important theorist in this communication technology - centric theory. Marshall McLuhan also supported the theory of Innis.

13.4.3 Toronto School

The three prominent scholars of the Toronto School, Harold Innis, Eric Havelock and McLuhan believed that communication technologies created psychological and sociological ‘states’ of society (Derrick de Kerckhove, 1989). The Toronto (or Canadian) School of Communication put forth a school of thought that technology had a mediated influence on society. According to this school, the study of the history of media and communication technologies was important in understanding the history of civilisation. Innis focused on the socio-economic and cultural effects of media, while McLuhan focused on the effects of media on people at the psychological and physiological levels (Leslie Regan Shade). This theory of media developed by the Toronto School is no doubt relevant today, with the pervasive influence of new media technologies creating a revolution in the way people communicate.

13.4.4 New Media and the Theory of Determinism

If McLuhan's electronic media resulted in the *global village*, the internet resulted in the *virtual world*. Information Society, being post - industrial, may be seen as a society with a predominant use of, in particular, computer-mediated communication. Production in an information society is based on "computers and other electronic devices to create, process, store, and apply information". (Macionis, 2005). Japan's vision of an information society, for example, was to have a 'computeropolis' or a central administration that was entirely computerised. An information economy requires workers who have symbolic skills like computing, designing, creating images, not to mention speaking and writing.

Identifying the present era as the Information Age or Information Society gives a continuity to the historical account of societies where eras are named after the technologies that shaped them.

Information Society may also be seen as a society where information is a 'commodity' and therefore, making information more valued and sought after is an essential economic strategy (Chakravartty and Sarikakis, 2006). It is no surprise then, that information/communication is produced, disseminated, and consumed continuously, consistently and in large measure today via social media like Facebook and Twitter. Facebook is the world's largest community, albeit virtual. The number of users of mobile phones increases in thousands each month. The search engine google is part of everybody's lives; new media technologies today, are part of our lives as 'coal, cotton and oil' that McLuhan says about the electronic media.

The Information Society, according to Webster, has some unique features (Lievrouw and Livingstone; eds, 2004):

- i) **Technological innovation and diffusion:** The Information Society got its name basically from the widespread production, dissemination and use of convergent communication technology.
- ii) **Occupational Change:** The rapid rise of the Information Technology industry has resulted in it being the most popular profession of the day.
- iii) **Economic Value:** The products of the Information Society are high in economic value. The software industry in India, for example, not only contributes significantly to the Indian economy in terms of employment etc., it also brings in a significant amount of foreign exchange.
- iv) **Information flows:** Obviously, an Information Society is highly networked in terms of communication and information, characterised by high speed, interactivity and multi level communication.
- v) **The expansion of symbols and signs:** Being global in nature, an Information Society is characterised by a complex network of communication flows and a widespread, multilevel dissemination of symbols and signs.

Today's communication technologies are creating an information and communication revolution, but are not serving all people equally (Paul Sagan, 2010). In fact, Internet and new media technologies are criticised for serving,

indirectly or openly, the vested interests of those who are promoting the spread of capitalism globally. (Edward Comor, 2001). Technologies of the Information Society are only tools that can supplement other efforts in areas that are crucial for development (Chakravartty and Sarikakis, 2006).

13.4.5 Implications on Human Communication

Communication is central to culture, because communication is crucial for cultures to develop, grow, exist, thrive and continue (McQuail, 2010). According to Croteau and Hoynes (2000), media technologies are user friendly and therefore have far-reaching significance. Different media offer different experiences. Being human inventions, media technologies both encourage and limit social action of people. The social significance of media technologies lies in the fact that they affect human communication. A significant influence of communication technologies is that it helps break the barriers of time and space. This has helped people communicate and keep in touch with those who are outside their range of personal communication, by post, telegraph and telephone, email, chat and social media, and mobile phone applications. People with access to digital media, therefore, are in a constant state of communication - either producing communication, receiving it, or searching for information; through texts, images, sound or videos.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Define Technological Determinism.

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2) Why are Innis and McLuhan considered Technological Determinists?

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3) What are the key features of the Information Society?

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13.5 CORE CONCEPTS

Let us now try to understand the core concepts in the theory, and the arguments of McLuhan, Innis and others. Was McLuhan a prophet or was his theory a mere exaggeration? You should be able to link the concepts together and analyse the theories and hypotheses put forth by them.

13.5.1 Explanation of Key Theory

Technological Determinism is a techno-centric theory based on the cause-effect philosophy. The cause–effect hypothesis states that every event has a cause and is in turn a cause for the next event. Applied to Technological Determinism, it translates into the assumption that technology is the main cause for the progress of society. This techno-centric ideology considers any new technology not just natural but also essential for society and culture (Burnett and Marshall, 2003).

Burnett and Marshall (2003) identify the following important elements of Technological Determinism:

- It assumes that any dominant technology will inevitably result in major cultural/social changes. This seems to be especially true with the dominant communication technology of the time. The influence/effect of the papyrus, the first printing machines, the newspaper, the broadcast media are considered important evidence.
- With technology being so influential, it is assumed that the influence may be for better or for worse. There are supporters of technology and of what it can achieve, as well as critics of technology and what it might mean to our future. The best example of this is nuclear technology. In communications, the mass media face the paradox of being both a boon and a bane to society and culture; as agents of integration and disintegration; as agents that provide continuity to culture and as agents that erode our culture.
- Technological Determinism is a kind of summarising or narrowing down of all possible influences on society and culture into one generalisable unit; thus making it a ‘reductionist’ approach to the understanding of the present and future societies.

The Toronto School of thought in communication assumed that of all technologies, communication technology is the most important factor that results in important social and cultural changes (Burnett and Marshall, 2003). According to McQuail, Communication Technology Determinism searches for ‘... links between the dominant communication technology of an age and key features of society...’ (McQuail, 2010, pg. 101)

Sociologist Gouldner’s study on the key political changes in modern political history also linked them to the dominant communication technology of the day. Printing and newspapers brought in new ideologies of the literati; whereas broadcast media, being truly mass in nature, resulted in a decline of ideologies of the intelligentsia and the growth of a new mass culture. According to McQuail (2010), a continuous decline in ideology can be anticipated with the rising popularity of the Internet and other computer-based networks of information.

13.5.2 Global Village

In his introduction to the book *Understanding Media* (1964), McLuhan refers to the media an extension of our senses and nerves. While, according to him, people extended their bodies in space in the mechanical world, in the electric world, (as he called it) people extended their very central nervous system to embrace the world. The electronic age is inclusive, there is no restricted association, and all

groups are involved in the lives of each other, made possible by electronic media. In the electric age, “the globe is no more than a village.” (McLuhan, 1964). According to Croteau and Hoynes (2000), the breaking of the space and time barriers (by electronic media technologies) has become a key aspect of globalisation, shrinking the world to a global village.

Unlike in the mechanical age, the electronic age expected people to declare themselves totally. The electronic age made people committed and participative, irrespective of their opinion/standpoint. While this may have seemed far-fetched when applied to television, it is arguably a standpoint one can relate to in today’s information age with social media being a platform of continuous communication of ideas/thoughts/feelings/happenings, making users participate in the mindboggling phenomenon of communication production, reception and dissemination in the virtual world. Social media has proved that people indeed are participative and committed, are at least driven to be so.

13.5.3 Medium is the Message

According to McLuhan, the message cannot exist without the medium, ‘it (the message) is a matter of indifference’ (McLuhan, 1964) because it is the medium that decides the extent of human association and action. The personal and social influence of the medium depends upon the introduction of new technologies or the new extension of ourselves. Therefore, he argued, the medium is the message (McLuhan, 1964). What McLuhan claimed was that it is the medium that counts: the medium is *itself* the message. This made him not just a technological determinist, but also a communication technological determinist.

13.5.4 Hot and Cold Media

McLuhan also introduced the concept of hot and cold media (1964). A hot medium, according to him, is “one that extends on single sense in high definition” (McLuhan, 1964). High definition refers to the state of a medium being highly informative by itself. Photographs, according to him, are high in definition and therefore hot. The cartoon, on the other hand, is a cool medium, because visually it provides very little information and therefore requires the effort and participation of the viewer. Similarly, the radio is a hot medium, and the telephone is a cool medium in terms of the amount of information these audio media provide to the ear. McLuhan labels the movie a hot medium while television is considered a cool medium.

13.5.5 Implications

So, what are its implications? McLuhan states, “hot media are ...low in participation and cool media are high in participation or completion by the audience” (McLuhan, 1964) and therefore, have different effects on the user. McLuhan goes on to apply this classification to other aspects of society and culture. The backward countries according to him are cool, and the developed countries are hot. Conversely, the mechanical past was hot and the modern electronic age or the age of TV is cool. A hot medium, if introduced in a cool culture, has far reaching consequences. Cool, ‘backward’ countries therefore, introduced radio for development, rather than for entertainment. This is to an extent true of the Indian experiment with radio for development. Let us not forget that television technology, McLuhan’s ‘cool’ medium, was also introduced in

India with the intention to use it for development. What is the involvement with cool media that McLuhan talks about? Ironically, it is not just the technology but also the message that requires audience to be part of the communication situation. So, is the medium really the message?

In addition, with television technology being high definition in terms of vision and sound today, even better than the photograph (visual) and the radio (sound), do they shift to being hot media? Does the use of radio, a hot medium, for education or development, not make it a cool medium, since it demands involvement from the target listeners? Going by McLuhan's definition of hot and cool media, this might be possible. It would be more reasonable to assume that most media technologies today are both hot and cold.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What does the phrase, 'the medium is the message' mean?

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2) Why McLuhan called Television a cool medium?

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3) Are the digital media hot or cool?

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13.6 RELATED THEORIES

Technological determinism theory has both supporters and critics. Many new theories have evolved endorsing this theory reinforcing the influence of technology in enabling people to take control of their lives. Critics of this viewpoint argue that the process of changing behaviour and society is not as simplistic as it is made out to be by this theory. Technology is shown to have immense power of driving the society and Chandler argues that technological determinism is a reductionist approach and reductionism is never a good approach in examining social phenomena (Chandler, 2000). The critics argue that technological determinism is an extreme theory and is not complete in itself to understand the sociological phenomena that shape human behaviour. In this context, let us examine some of the related and opposing theories to understand technological, social, and cultural forces that are potent enough to change the society.

13.6.1 Social Determinism and Cultural Determinism

We have understood that there is no one single variable that can have a significant influence on social actions and thought. While Social Determinism, as opposed to Technological Determinism, believes that social interactions and social variables influence human behaviour, Cultural Determinism, as opposed to Genetic/Biological Determinism, believes that cultural factors have a great role to play in influencing human behaviour.

13.6.2 Thomas L. Friedman

Journalist, author, three-time Pulitzer Prize winner, Friedman is best remembered for his seminal work, *The Earth is Flat- A Brief History of the Twenty-first Century* (2005). In this book, Friedman talks of the rapidly developing communications and technology that has, among other things levelled the global competitive field; thus, enabling people to try to take control of their own economic futures, from wherever they are. Real time collaborations and competition is made possible by the new information and communication technologies (Friedman, 2005).

This approach not only talks of how technology can bring about changes, but also about how people make use of the potential of rapidly developing technologies. Friedman points out that in a world where societies increasingly have similar technological innovations, it is human talent that acts as the prime differentiator in the process of development/growth.

13.6.4 Associated Theories

Based on Fishbein and Ajzen's Theory of Reasoned Action, the *Technological Acceptance Model* put forth by Davis F.D. tried to explain computer usage behaviour of people (Malhotra and Galletta). The basic premise of this model is that perceived utility and perceived ease of application/use of a new technology influences attitudes towards its adoption. According to Rao, several factors influence attitudes. The important ones are: perception of the ease of adoption, concerns about use of the technology, perception of the usefulness of the technology and the pleasures or enjoyment of using the technology.

13.6.5 Opposing Theories

Croteau and Hoynes (2000) criticise the theory of Technological Determinism because it lacks the human element. Technological Determinism according to them seems to imply that people are used by technology, rather than the other way round. Both viewpoints have to be considered to understand the relationship between media and society. The authors point out that it is important to consider the social forces that developed and accepted media technology in order to appreciate their significance. Further, the authors argue that to consider the message as not separate from the medium is an oversimplification of the media communication process.

According to Vanderburg (2012), before technology can be considered deterministic or autonomous, it has to satisfy three parameters: It must have the capacity to encompass to a great extent, the way of life in a society. Second, culture should place on it (technology) a very high value. Third, technology should be dominant enough to diminish the role of the symbolic way of living that is culture.

Vanderburg believes that technology and society can be studied from both ends of the spectrum of technological neutrality - society having significant influence over technology- to the other end of the spectrum of technological determinism. In between this spectrum, he says, are technologies of the 'so-called underdeveloped societies'. Industrialisation could be an example of Technological Determinism. Vanderburg opines that relationship between technologies and societies need careful analysis. He contends that the influences are always reciprocal.

The Social Shaping of Technology (SST) approach is in direct contrast to Technological Determinism. As an opposing theory/school of thought, SST believes and tries to show that technology is a 'social product' (Williams and Edge, 1996). The fact that society dictates the creation and use of a technology indicates the presence of choice. SST theories therefore attribute the success or failure of a technology to the acceptance/rejection of the technology by society. These choices may result in successful technologies being developed cumulatively since they prove to be profitable. It could also result in stability of certain innovations, or a reversal of earlier choices.

Social accountability and control of technology, are priorities with SST theories (Williams and Edge, 1996). However, there exists a plurality of ideas and arguments about the methods of social intervention in and social control of technological innovations, and in the very character of technology itself. The SST theory is strongly supported by sociologists who work in the area of new media research today. Although new media, especially the Internet, seem to have important, unwanted social and psychological effects, its use is primarily in the hands of individuals and society.

The philosophy today is that technology and society shape each other, and this outlook has been an important guiding force in communication and information research since the 1980s (Livingstone and Lievrouw (Eds.), 2004).

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit

1) Mention some opposing theories of Technological Determinism.

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2) List the main arguments of the opposing theories.

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- 3) Briefly outline the main points of Social Shaping of Technology theory.

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Activity-1

Identify a research topic based on the Technological Acceptance Model.

13.7 LET US SUM UP

Technological Determinism is today an accepted viewpoint; but so is the understanding that technologies are tools, and hence, need the human hand to wield it in a way that benefits all. Technological Determinism is the premise that technology effects our lives socially, economically and culturally. Technology shapes society is the argument of Technological Determinism. It is an autonomous force and the significant driver in our lives. The three prominent scholars of the Toronto School, Harold Innis, Eric Havelock and McLuhan are the proponents of this theory who have asserted that technology has sociological, cultural and psychological effects on the society. The concepts of Global Village, Medium is the Message and Hot and Cold Media coined by McLuhan have initiated discourse on the influence of technology on the society.

The main arguments of the opposing theories and hypotheses are that factors other than technology as being the dominant, determining factors in shaping the major features of any society. Societal development, societal growth, and cultural advancement are dependent not just on technologies, but also on social and cultural forces. Theorists today agree that it is not one construct but the interplay of several factors that shape society; and this has been brought out with clarity in the arguments and viewpoints discussed in the Unit.

13.8 FURTHER READINGS

Comor Edward (2001). Harold Innis and the Bias of Communication, Information, Communication & Society, 4:2, 274-294

Croteau David and Hoynes William (2000). Media/Society Industries, Images and audiences 2nd ed., Pine Forge Press, California

Marshall McLuhan (1964). Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man, Routledge and Kegan Paul, United Kingdom

McQuail Denis (2010). McQuail's Mass Communication Theory, SAGE Publications India Pvt. Ltd., New Delhi

13.9 KEY TERMS

Bias of communication: It can be understood as the tendency of media to lean towards a particular kind of mediation.

Communication Technology Determinism: The sequence of invention and application of communication technology influences social change (McQuail, 2010).

Culture: It is “the values, beliefs, behaviour; and material objects that together form a people’s way of life” (Macionis, 2005).

Global village: First used by McLuhan. According to Croteau and Hoynes (2000), the breaking of the space and time barriers (by electronic media technologies) has become a key aspect of globalisation, shrinking the world to a global village.

Hot and Cold media: McLuhan also introduced the concept of hot and cold media (1964). A hot medium, according to him, is “one that extends on single sense in high definition” (McLuhan, 1964). High definition refers to the state of a medium being highly informative by itself. A cool medium provides very little information and therefore requires the effort and participation of the viewer.

Medium is the message: According to McLuhan, the message cannot exist without the medium, ‘it (the message) is a matter of indifference’ (1964) because it is the medium that decides the extent of human association and action.

Popular Culture: Refers to that aspect of the society that is part of everyday life, and is pervasive. It is mass produced and mass consumed, and heavily influenced by mass media (Andersen and Taylor, 2007)

Social Determinism and Cultural Determinism: While Social Determinism believes that social interactions and social variables influence human behaviour, Cultural Determinism believes that cultural factors have a great role to play in influencing human behaviour.

Society: Refers to “people who interact in a defined territory and share a culture” (Macionis, 2005)

The Social Shaping of Technology: This approach is in direct contrast to Technological Determinism. As an opposing theory/school of thought, SST believes and tries to show that technology is a ‘social product’ (Williams and Edge, 1996).

Technology: Refers to those “methods, systems, and devices which are the result of scientific knowledge being used for practical purposes” (Collins Dictionary).

Technological Determinism: This is a theory first proposed by American sociologist, Thorstein Veblen, which states, “the improvement of society’s cultural values and social structure is driven by the technology it possesses” .

Technological Acceptance Model: The basic premise of this model is that perceived utility and perceived ease of application/use of a new technology influences attitudes towards its adoption.

13.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) The Collins Dictionary defines technology as referring to those “methods, systems, and devices which are the result of scientific knowledge being used for practical purposes.” The dictionary also defines the technologies as “the system by which a society provides its members with those things needed or desired”
- 2) Simply put, Society refers to people who live together as communities within geographic boundaries, interact, work, and share a common culture. Culture is a way of life, of shared values and codes. Society and culture work towards growth, both are vibrant and have far reaching implications on every aspect of life: social, economic, political, educational, religious, in fact on the very landscape of the earth that we live in. This could be called civilisation.
- 3) Communication is an important feature of culture; it is crucial for cultural and societal growth. The media of mass communication play a vital role in the continuity of cultures, in the process, they also have widespread influence in the way people live, think and behave.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) Technological Determinism; as the term states, indicates that technology determines the key features of a society.
- 2) Innis and McLuhan theorised that technology is crucial in shaping social thoughts and actions, and that the most important technology was communication technology.
- 3) The Information Society, being post-industrial, may be seen as a society with a predominant use of, in particular, computer-mediated communication. Information is the key product in an information society.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Owing to the hugely significant impact of the electronic mass media on society, McLuhan declared that the ‘the medium is the message’; it was the medium that was the catalyst and not any other element of mass communication.
- 2) McLuhan classified television as a cool medium because it did not have high definition of any of the senses; either seeing (photographs) or listening (radio), and therefore demanded the involvement of the user.
- 3) Digital media are convergent media, a convergence of hot and cool media. It is cool because it draws people to it, people are made to be involved and participate, it is hot because it is high definition in visuals, sound, and even text.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) Some opposing theories of Technological Determinism are Social Determinism, Cultural Determinism theories, and Biological Determinism theories. The most important opposing argument is the Social Shaping of Technology theory.
- 2) The main arguments of the opposing theories and hypotheses are that factors other than technology as being the dominant, determining factors in shaping the major features of any society. Theorists today agree that it is not one construct but the interplay of several factors that shape society.
- 3) The Social Shaping of Technology approach is in direct contrast to Technological Determinism. As an opposing theory/school of thought, SST believes and tries to show that technology is a product or creation of society.



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UNIT 14 MEDIA AND THE PUBLIC SPHERE

Structure

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- 14.2 Key Elements and their Relationships
 - 14.2.1 Political Communication
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- 14.6 Let Us Sum Up
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14.0 INTRODUCTION

Jurgen Habermas' understanding of Public Sphere is a space where citizens and the public body who assemble freely and express their opinion which forms public opinion. Hence, public sphere and public opinion are correlated.

In this unit, we shall discuss the relationship between Media, Public Sphere, and Public Opinion. In fact, the debates in Public Sphere are usually on Socio-political economic issues. Moreover, the media is a major platform for political debates, which in turn act as a public sphere, therefore, the unit will include deliberations on all these issues.

14.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading through this unit you should be able to:

- discuss the relationship between media and Public Sphere;
- analyse media content acting as Public Sphere by George Orwell, Noam Chomsky;

- explain the Political Economy of media;
- discuss Habermas' theory of Public Sphere;
- analyse the relevance of Habermas today; and
- describe some cases of media and Public Sphere.

14.2 KEY ELEMENTS AND THEIR RELATIONSHIPS

When we refer to media and Public Sphere, public sphere is considered to be a place or an area in social life where individuals can come together to freely discuss any societal problem and through that discussion influence political action. In fact, media is supposed to support and promote this discussion. Therefore, the public sphere is where debates occur on socio-political and economic aspects. The public sphere is also an arena where issues of all sections of society are held and through this, citizens form opinions, which become public opinion.

14.2.1 Political Communication

The political communication is the role of communication in the political process. Every act of a political communication produced by parties, interest groups, or the media is geared towards citizens to inform them and to influence them. It can take place in variety of mediated or unmediated content. Political communication has emerged as a focal point to scholars in political science, communication and allied social sectors. However, the mass media are the public sphere and mediate between citizens on the one hand and the institutions of the Government on the other (Joseph and Lynda L Kaid 2008).

In political communication, media are the primary points of access to politics and the place for political encounters. The political parties' communication becomes the major tool to seek mandate and get votes for them.

The purpose of all such communication is to persuade audience without which no political message can have any relevance. Whatever the size and nature of the audience, political communication is intended to achieve an effect on the receivers of the message. Political communication has always been central to the electoral and policymaking process.

14.2.2 Public Opinion and Media

The hidden mandate of the media is to influence and generate a positive public opinion of the people towards any idea that it is promoting. Moreover, the media by default, creates an informed public by acting as a forum for debates and discussion i.e. an arena or space for the discourse. Public opinions are generally ideas and attitudes of citizens. People have opinions about political issues. The factors that generally affect public opinion are family institutions, peers, media, opinion leaders, historic events.

Publics can be many; more than one public can exist at the same time. Media play a huge role in shaping public opinion. The media 'tells the people what to think about' in society. The major public opinion formed is based on electoral politics and politicians use media coverage to their advantage.

The mass media set the agenda for each political campaign, influencing public attitudes towards political issues. Public opinion plays an important role in a democratic society as political leaders can take into account, the public opinion when forming laws and making policies as people are the ultimate in democratic set up.

In fact, most theorists agree that there is a link between media and public opinion. But, what they disagree is which one has the more influence and how this works. Some media theorists suggest that media has a very significant influence on the actions of the audience. But, others feel that it is the audience who decide what media means and therefore anything that is there in the media is not influential unless it supports what the members of the audience already believe.

The main outline of this influence of the media were sketched by Walter Lippmann in 1922's classic "Public Opinion" in which he noted, the news media are a primary source of those 'pictures in our heads' about the larger world of public affairs; what we know about the world is largely based on what the media decide to tell us.

The general shape of public opinion in an issue can be found through variety of means: elections: mandate – an indicator of public opinion; interest groups – i.e. pressure groups have an opinion of their own; the media – described as 'mirrors' as well as 'moulders' of public opinion; public opinion polls.

14.2.3 Propaganda and Media

Propaganda intends to manipulate the audience emotion, behaviour, and attitudes. It is also manipulation of information to influence public opinion. You have read in the previous units that propaganda was used during the World War I, when a variety of interacting political, commercial, military and technological factors had produced a range of media through which propaganda could be disseminated. Both sides of the war conflicts used propaganda to shape international opinion. People were not only informed about the war through the media, but also the government used the media systematically to compel the public to alter their opinion.

Traditionally, the word Propaganda has been considered as the manipulation of opinions toward political, religious, or military ends. Propaganda in the media can be characterised by some of the following versions:

- A heavy reliance on authoritative spokesman, rather than empirical validation;
- Utilisation of unverified abstract norms, adjectives, adverbs to establish truths, conclusion or impressions;
- A finalist and fixed views of peoples, institutions, divided into broad, all inclusive categories;
- A reduction of situations into readily identifiable cause-effect relationships;
- A greater emphasis on conflict than cooperation among people, institutions, and situations;

Hence, propaganda challenges the very foundation of principles of mass media to a certain extent. In fact, propaganda has invariably become a part of the media and creeps into the public sphere.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is Political Communication?

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2) Discuss the role of media in public opinion.

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3) Explain the characteristics of propaganda in media.

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14.3 INITIAL DEBATES

Much of the discussions on media and public sphere revolve around the way some philosophers and professors of communication, sociology, and psychology have deliberated on the topic. The idea of media being a platform or an arena to discuss politics, societal matter, and other issues in democracy has been the crux of the matter deliberated upon by many of these philosophers. The ideology of George Orwell and Noam Chomsky on media and public sphere are part of the initial debates.

14.3.1 George Orwell

George Orwell was an ardent socialist and in a way, laid the foundation for political debates in a social arena. Eric Arthur Blair, born in British Colony of India was known by his pen name George Orwell. He was a novelist and a journalist. Orwell's most popular books *1984* and *Animal Farm* discuss an ideology against totalitarianism and communism. Orwell thought that all political theories and ideologies except socialism are hopeless and disillusioning. According to him totalitarianism makes people to think individually. The best way to control people's mind is in the social and psychological way. Orwell argued that people are controlled by media.

14.3.2 Noam Chomsky

Avram Noam Chomsky is an American linguist, historian, political critic, and activist who has written on varied topics including politics and mass media and is an author of over 100 books. He has become well known for his critiques on US Foreign Policy, State capitalism and the mainstream news media. His media

criticism has included ‘Manufacturing Consent: The Political Economy of Mass Media’ (1988), an analysis articulating the propaganda model theory for examining the media.

He describes his views as ‘fairly traditional, anarchist, with origins in the classical liberalism’. A rationalist, Chomsky is suspicious of big media, big business and big government. Noam Chomsky’s theorising is on topics that include Value, Consensus, Human Nature, Learning, Society, Transmission, Knowledge and Opportunity.

Chomsky is often compared to Bertrand Russell and he responds to ideologies of Descartes and Plato as he considers them to be corner stones of rationalism. Chomsky’s debates on media are often related to Propaganda, Public Sphere, and Public Opinion. He is a strong critic of the media as a major profit making business, which tends to manipulate consent of the public.

14.3.3 Manufacturing Consent

‘Manufacturing Consent: The Political Economy of the Mass Media’ written by Noam Chomsky and Edward S Herman. The book became so popular that a documentary ‘Manufacturing Consent: Noam Chomsky and the Media’ was made. Chomsky in this book considers that the news media is a big business and therefore news is a commodity subject to ‘bias’ as any other product. Noam Chomsky opines that if news is to make profit, then what they air, know they report and ‘what is reported’ will be based on ‘profit’.

The major function of the news media has to be to report events objectively, to allow citizens to make informed political choices; to control governmental abuses of power, through investigative journalism. But this, according to Chomsky and Edward is never done by the media. For instance, the then UN Secretary General Kofi Annan called the Iraq War ‘Illegal’, but this was never mentioned by the media. Noam Chomsky says ‘the media creates artificial fears with a dual purpose in partly to get rid of people you don’t like but partly to frighten the rest because, if people are frightened, they will accept authority.’

You may refer to Unit 12 on Political Economy for further information on manufacturing of consent.

14.3.4 Media Hegemony

Hegemony originates from Greek verb ‘Hegesthai’ which means ‘Lead’. Early leaders were able to exert a great deal of control and influence over a group of people might be referred to as ‘Hegemons’. Media hegemony implies that the ideas of the ruling class become the most important ideas of the society. In other words, the rulers impose their ideas on the masses. As per this, mass media are controlled by the dominant/ ruling class in society, which uses media as a vehicle to exert control over the rest of the society.

Mass media organisations are owned by big corporates in almost all countries of the world. It becomes imperative to note that whoever controls the media also controls the masses’ mind. Media has the capacity to impose ideas through headlines, pictures, stories which can be easily manipulated.

Hegemony can also be considered as a certain kind of power that arises from the all embracing ideological tendencies of mass media to support power system and exclude opposition and competing values (McQuail, 2010). Moreover, media hegemony occurs when a dominant ruling class (Lasorsa, 2002) dominates and influences the remaining members of the society. Gramsci argued that in 20th Century western democracies, the ruling classes ruled through hegemony.

Political hegemony works through leadership and always tries to express power. For instance, bigger nations want to control smaller ones. Media plays an important role in all kinds of hegemony, as it is the forum for dissemination of any information. However, it need not always be correct, as pluralism is a part of society and people have every freedom and choice to decide. Pluralists argue that media hegemony may not be possible. Nevertheless, media hegemony does play an important role in media, and public sphere as the debates happens in the media.

14.3.5 Political Economy of Media

Media and Politics have a strong nexus. Moreover, the economy of media is often regulated by politics. It is an open secret in the present century that most of the media barons are having some relationship with politics or political leadership.

The political communication, news, or media is a particular branch in communication studies which studies the power relations (political economy) that constitute the communication of information from mass media to public. The understanding of political economy of mass media is an approach to studying media focus towards the way in which media is produced, distributed, and consumed. In fact, the idea is to reflect on how does the ownership affect the media?

According to Political Economy of Communication Theory (PEOC); means and entertainment are largely centrally controlled and the masses have little choice in the sources of information as all media outlets give more or less the same information. For instance, the same proprietors own major channels and conglomerates. Even the software and social media networks are centralised by Microsoft, Facebook, Apple, and others. In India, half of the TV, Radio and Print media, are owned by corporates.

Correlating Public Sphere with Political Economy of Communication theories shows that public sphere is non-existent in this environment because most of the media content comes from owners with vested economic interests and it is difficult to find a neutral space for debates. It becomes irrelevant whether a media organisation allows for a great degree of interactivity as you don't have any control over it and it is the owner who controls it.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit

1) What is manufacturing consent?

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2) Explain Gramsci concept of hegemony.

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3) Describe the concept of political economy of media.

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14.4 CORE CONCEPTS

The important factors generally discussed in media and public sphere are public sphere, media, and public discourse. Public sphere is an area in social life where individuals can come together to freely discuss and identify societal problems and through that discussion influence political action. Public discourse is one of the most important aspects of democracy.

14.4.1 Explanation of Key Theory

The fundamental theory was put forward by German Sociologist, Political Thinker, Jurgen Habermas as 'Bourgeois Public Sphere' in his seminal work, 'The Structural transformation of the Public Sphere' (1962). The Bourgeois Public Sphere may be conceived above all as 'the sphere of private people coming together as public, they soon claimed the public sphere regulated from above against public authorities themselves, to engage them in a debate over the general rules governing relations in the basically privatised but publicly relevant sphere of commodity exchange and social labour'.

The emergence of bourgeois in public sphere was particularly supported by the 18th century liberal democracy making resources evaluate to this new political class to establish a network of institutions like publishing houses, newspapers and discussion forums.

Habermas argues that through acts of assembly and dialogue, the public sphere generates opinions, which serve to affirm or challenge or to guide the affairs of the state. Public sphere is a virtual or imaginary community, which does not necessarily exist in any identifiable space, but it tries to create access, autonomy, and participation to the people and sets public free from colonisation and feudalisation of society.

The following are the key elements of Public Sphere:

- It is a domain where public opinion can be formed after public discussions;
- It is open to all citizens who are private persons but care for public interest and come together for general interest to form public sphere;
- It is a forum for citizens to freely express their opinions on public issues connected to government and politics;

- Public sphere provides a platform to mediate between state and public in public issues; and
- It is a liberal model ideal in a democratic polity.

14.4.2 Habermas and Public Sphere

Habermas explored the status of public opinion in the practice of representative government in Western Europe. According to him, in its ideal form the public sphere is “made up of private people gathered together as a public and articulating the needs of society with the state” (Habermas 1962). A Public Sphere began to emerge in the 18th Century through the growth of the coffee houses, literary and other societies. Habermas argues that the later part of 19th and 20th century, the press did not act as a Public Sphere because newspapers became profit oriented and business interests turned the press into an agent of manipulation. He said ‘privileged private interests invaded the public sphere’.

Death of Bourgeois

Nineteenth century saw an expanding public sphere with the growth of the media and technological development, literacy spread, increased working class and improved industrialisation. Participation of alienated groups changed the ideologies of public discourse so also the content in the press changed. According to Jurgen Habermas, structural transformation of political public sphere was ‘re-feudalisation’ where the distinction of ‘Public’ and ‘Private’ could not be easily applied. As the bourgeois public sphere disintegrated, Habermas reflects on the ideology of the media providing a site for public participation and wonders whether the mass media having a great power could be harnessed for public good?

Brief Introduction to Jurgen Habermas

Jurgen Habermas was born on 18th June 1929, at Dusseldorf, Germany. He obtained his Doctorate from the University of Marburg. He is a known ‘Sociologist’ and ‘Philosopher’ in the tradition of ‘Critical Theory’ and ‘Pragmatism.’ He is perhaps best known for his theories on ‘Communicative Rationality’ and ‘Public Sphere.’ As a young teenager, he was impacted by World War II. His father was descanted as a Nazi sympathiser and Habermas was brought up as a Protestant. Habermas studied Philosophy and Sociology in the Frankfurt School under critical theorists Mark Horkheimer and Theodore Adorno. His classic work, ‘The Structural Transformation of the PS’ was based on bourgeois public sphere. It gives a detailed account of the development of bourgeois public sphere in the 18th century and the transformation due to the influence of capital driven mass media.

Habermas and other theorists of Public Sphere

John P Thomson, Professor of Sociology at the University of Cambridge, claims that the Habermas’s notion of Public Sphere is old due to the proliferation of mass media. Michael Schudson, University of California, argues that more generally public sphere as a place of rational independent debate never existed. Nancy Fraser, Professor of Political Science and Philosophy says that these are multiple spheres and counter publics.

Although Habermas happens to be the central theorist of public sphere, where he says that once a person is idealised he is allowed to speak, interact and take

action in collective decision. According to him public sphere is an arena where 'rational-critical argument' takes place without violence, but there are many other theorists of public sphere who are critical of his argument. His student Oscar Negt and colleague Alexander Kluge argue that the bourgeois public sphere that Habermas refers to have no meaning in the times of the advanced structural changes and the media cartel.

Many defenders and critics of Habermas's notion of the bourgeois public sphere fail to note that the thrust of his study is precisely that of transformation, of the mutations of the public sphere from a space of rational discussion, debate and consensus to a realm of mass cultural consumption and administration by corporations and dominant elites.

Habermas's critics argue that he idealises the earlier bourgeois public sphere by presenting a rational discussion and debate when in fact certain groups were excluded and participation was thus limited. Oscar Negt and Alexander Kluge criticised Habermas's neglect of Plebian and Proletarian public sphere.

Mary Ryan notes that not only did Habermas neglect Women's public sphere but marks the decline of public sphere precisely at the moment when women were beginning to get political power and become actors (1992:259).

In Kellner's view, Habermas does not adequately theorise the nature and social functions of contemporary media and information, they are for him mere mechanism of transmitting messages, instruments that are neither an essential part of the economy nor polity.

14.4.3 Media and Public Sphere

Among the institutions that contribute to the make-up of public sphere the media performs the most crucial function. In the transactions of public sphere, the media play an important role by intervening between the public and the state. Herbert Schiller, a theoretician of repute, says media in public sphere is a 'Mind Manager' implying it can have a bearing on the ideological mindset of people.

About media, he argues that, 'today newspapers and magazines, radio and television are the media of the public sphere' (Habermas, 1984:49). In the present situation, the re-feudalised public sphere is the mass media with its power relations like the ownership and control, ad revenue, public relations and 'Spin Culture.' Habermas is highly critical of media in public sphere and he calls it as pseudo-public-sphere and says that we have moved from culture-debating to a culture-consuming public (Habermas 1989).

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Write a note on Habermas' concept of Public Sphere.

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- 2) Name the other scholars who contributed to Public Sphere.

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- 3) Discuss the role of media in Public Sphere?

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14.5 POLITICAL PARTICIPATION AND HABERMAS THEORY

While talking about political participation, one has to distinguish between participation in a directly political context, such as elections or political institutions, parties or interest groups and participation in social context. Whatever kind of political participation, Habermas theorised that human beings possess communicative competence through the course of evolution and with an activist public sphere, there could be a political participation of the civic society in a democracy.

14.5.1 Relevance of Habermas Theory

Habermasian theory of bourgeois public sphere and its death in 19th century with the expanding growth of mass media, when he himself reflects whether the media could be harnessed for the public good is perhaps relevant even today.

The traditional Habermasian concept of the national public sphere created by the mass media of newspapers and TV is now transformed into a multi-layered sphere of online and Social Networking Sites (SNS) which are increasingly important in engaging and mobilising masses and in shaping the discourse of rational thinking. But the open participation of the internet can turn chaotic as there is a problem of inclusiveness and there is a censorship issue. The content can be partisan and fake. Moreover, extensive dialogue and threadbare discussion, which is the core aspect of public sphere, is totally absent in the internet.

14.5.2 Some Cases of Media and Public Sphere

Since the time of Habermas' bourgeois public sphere to the present, a number of researches and critiques have been reported. After the millennium the discussions on media and public sphere have increased. The following are some relevant cases that deal with media and public sphere:

a) Political SMS as Public Sphere: A Case Study of the Norwegian Labour Party

The Norwegian Labour Party is Norway's largest political party and has online/ digital communication. The objective is to spread information about the party's policies and events. The site is divided into regional, local zones and topic zone. The findings indicate that several people address each other's

comments on different topics. Some also share content to other sites (other than Mylabor party site). The most popular topics receiving comments are related to internal party issues. In fact, this case study supports the argument the internet as public sphere is very much active and the networked public sphere requires both an internal public and the public that provide content from one discussion space to other spaces.

b) Social Media as a new form of Public Sphere

The study was a qualitative analysis of different forms of Social Media by Erlis Cela, Bedler University. She concludes that when you compare the countries with increasing number of the users in social networks around the world with the countries declining of the newspaper circulation, it is clear that we are living in a new era of communication. The social media or the 'virtual space' is drawing more number of people. The borders between the producer and the consumer of information are completely invisible due to the social media. This phenomenon has made communication more democratic by empowering simple people who were passive in the past. It shows that the political and public discourse is taking place in a virtual environment- Virtual public sphere.

c) The Digital Public Sphere: An alternative and Counter-hegemonic Space. The case of Spain.

This is a case study by Victor Sampedro and Maysa Martinez Avidad of the University of Ray Juan Carlos, Spain. Their findings indicate that in late 2000s, a counter hegemonic public sphere did exist. Internet and mobile technology created discourse frames and they articulated and expressed new political system against hegemony. This new public sphere makes the citizens activate citizens' frames to interpret and participate in public affairs.

d) Reconstructing the Indian Public Sphere: Newswork and Social Media in the Delhi Gang rape case

A study by Valerie Belair – Gagvon, Yale Law School, USA, Smeeta Mishra, Centre for Culture, Media and Governance, JMS (India), Colin Agere, Columbia University, Graduate School of Journalism, USA.

The researchers found that social media was still marginal in India's public sphere. It was found through interviews of journalists, relationship with social media that there was an emergence of networked public sphere based on 'new spaces of flows' in India. The Delhi gang rape case was seen in networked space as a new form of storytelling and a participatory culture of online conversations. Journalists used social media for background information on the Delhi Gang rape and Anna Hazare cases.

e) Indian Public Sphere in the Social Media era

According to a paper by Usha Rodrigues, Deakin University, New Zealand there are two Indias – one that comprises of urban and rural elite and the other includes the poor and the marginalised. This also reflects the 'digital divide.' The mainstream media is increasingly using the Internet to connect with their audiences. Indian politicians are using Twitter, Facebook, Google as Public Sphere. The Indian networked population, have a sense of direct

access to their political leaders because of social media. Despite the digital divide, the engagement of voters and citizens, particularly the educated youth, is a sign of expanding public sphere in India.

14.5.3 Political Participation, New Media and Democracy

Democracy and politics in the digital era have altogether changed the public sphere. Mainstream media is relatively less used by politicians for seeking votes or other information and the rule of the day is Facebook, MySpace, Twitter, Instagram and other Social Networking Sites.

Recently, scholars tested how digital media are used for informational purposes to foster democratic processes. There is anecdotal informational evidence that shows that Social Networking Sites can have a pro-social effect. Using Social Networking Sites for information purpose does have a positive impact on bringing civic and political action. All this leads to considering using New Media as a tool for democracy. In short, Social Networking Sites also seem to provide adequate and relevant information to emphasise the democratic process.

The internet and its surrounding technologies hold the promise of reviving the democratic public sphere, but several aspects of these technologies do simultaneous curtail and also augment that potential. First, the data stored and retrieved do infuse political discussion time and again which otherwise not easily available. At the same time, information access inequalities and new media literacy compromise the cross section representativeness in the virtual public sphere. Second, the Social Media based technology enables political discussion between people far and wide across globe, but it also fragmentises political discourse. Third, the global capitalism leads to internet based technologies to adapt to current political culture, rather create a new one. However, the Social Networking Sites, have created a new public space for political participation but how they do create a new public sphere depends on the technology.

In India, political participation through new media was initially seen only during elections. But, now it is successfully used as a tool to fight corruption, political protests and such related issues.

A study conducted on the 2014 elections notes that the electoral success of BJP was associated with Twitter in engaging voters. The main feature of these sites that help people to be informed in that, they provide information faster than news channels. Many politicians have taken to Social Media like fish to water and their updates on Facebook, keep people informed about latest happenings in politics.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is political participation according to Habermas?

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14.6 LET US SUM UP

Media and Public Sphere are relative terms; with the technological developments of the media, public sphere has become more individualistic and personalised and the social media makes debates individualistic, leading to debates.

Political Communication has an important role to play as a subject of discussion in public sphere with the media acting as a public sphere or forum for debates on politics. Vertically information flows from the Government, through the media to people and horizontally media acts as a forum (Public Sphere) for debates among citizens.

Public Opinion is generally based on politics. The media acts as an information outlet for politicians and political parties and based on this the public forms public opinion. Most media theorists agree that there is a link between media and public opinion. In other words, media makes or sets the political agenda for people to form public opinion. Propaganda is an extension of public opinion and it is manipulation of information to influence public opinion.

There are some important theorists of media and public sphere, George Orwell who was an ardent Socialist, opined that the totalitarianism had made people to think as what the Government thinks and media controls the people. Noam Chomsky's book 'Manufacturing Consent' considers news as a biased commodity meant to make profit. Chomsky criticises media for acting only in favour of the government/ advertisers and the private investors and not as a public sphere debating issues truthfully.

Media hegemony is all pervading issue of media as public sphere. According to media hegemony, the media supports the ruling government and the public debate will be based on such pro-government issues.

Political Economy of Media and politics are inter-related. Most media barons have a strong relationship with political parties and politicians; the economy of the media depends on the partisanship and economy of the media becomes more important than policies and ideologies. Hence, the media public sphere debates issues that pro-economy of the media.

Public Sphere propounded by Habermas is a domain where public opinion can be formed after public discussions. It is open to all citizens who are private persons but care for public interest and come together for general interest to form public sphere. It is a forum for citizens to freely express their opinions on public issues connected to government and politics

About media, Habermas argues that, 'today newspapers and magazines, radio and television are the media of the public sphere' (Habermas, 1984:49). In the present situation, the re-feudalised public sphere is the mass media with its power

relations like the ownership and control, ad revenue, public relations and ‘Spin Culture.’ Habermas is highly critical of media in public sphere and he calls it as pseudo-public-sphere and says that we have moved from culture-debating to a culture-consuming public (Habermas 1989).

The Habermas theory of bourgeois public sphere has changed in the present day context. Development of media technologies and structural changes have made media the most powerful tools in influencing public opinion. A number of research studies have been conducted on media and public sphere all over the world and most of them have found that the Social Media plays a vital role as public sphere in the contemporary times.

14.7 FURTHER READINGS

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Hardt, Michael; Antonio Negri (2004), *Multitude: war and democracy in the age of Empire*, New York: The Penguin Press.

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14.8 KEY TERMS

Public Sphere: The sphere of private people come together as a public, to engage in a debate over the general rules governing relations in the basically privatised but publicly relevant sphere to influence political action.

Media Hegemony: Media hegemony implies that the ideas of the ruling class become the most important ideas of the society.

Political Economy: The economy of media is often regulated by politics. It is power relationships between media, political decision making and economy.

14.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Broadly defined, political communication is the role of communication in the political process. Every act of a political communication produced by parties, interest groups, or the media is geared towards citizens to inform and influence them.

- 2) The hidden mandate of media is to influence and generate a positive public opinion of the people towards any idea that it is promoting.
- 3) The characteristics of propaganda in media are:
 - A heavy reliance on authoritative spokesman, rather than empirical validation.
 - Utilisation of unverified abstract norms, adjectives, adverbs to establish truths, conclusion or impressions.
 - A finalist and fixed views of peoples, institutions, divided into broad, all inclusive categories.
 - A reduction of situations into readily identifiable cause-effect relationships.
 - A greater emphasis on conflict than cooperation among people, institutions and situations.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) 'Manufacturing consent: The Political Economy of Mass Media' (1988) is an analysis articulating the propaganda model theory for examining the media.
- 2) Gramsci argued that in 20th Century western democracies, the ruling classes ruled through hegemony. He suggested that across society, there were many interest groups and people were aligned to them. These groups could be religious, democratic reformists and the ruling class relied for its hegemonic survival on them.
- 3) The political economy of mass media is an approach to studying media focus towards the way in which media is produced, distributed and consumed. In fact, the idea is to reflect on how ownership affects the media.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) According to Habermas, Public Sphere is a space where individuals can come together to freely discuss and identify societal problems and through that discussion influence political action.
- 2) John P Thomson, Michael Schudson, Nancy Fraser were some other scholars who contributed to Public Sphere.
- 3) Among the institutions that contribute to the make-up of public sphere the media performs the most crucial function. In the transactions of public sphere, the media play an important role by intervening between the public and the state.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) Habermas believed that human beings possess communicative competence through the course of evolution and with an active public sphere, there could be a political participation of the civic society in a democracy.
- 2) The traditional Habermasian concept of the national public sphere created by the mass media of newspapers and TV is now transformed into a multi-layered sphere of online and Social Networking Sites (SNS) which are increasingly important in engaging and mobilising masses and shaping the discourse of rational thinking.

UNIT 15 AUDIENCE THEORIES

Structure

15.0 Introduction

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15.3.4 Types of Audience

15.4 Structure of Audience Theories

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15.6 Let Us Sum Up

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15.8 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

15.0 INTRODUCTION

As you are aware, the end users of media are the audience. The whole process of communication lays importance on the feedback from the audience. Communication process is said to be effective ‘if and only if’ there is a response from the receiver.

An ideal audience is a communicator’s imagined, intended audience. In creating a rhetorical text, the communicator or the speaker imagines a target audience, a group of individuals that will be addressed, persuaded, or affected by the speech or the rhetorical text.

Audience could be a person or a mass – it can be of varied sizes and kinds. The audience theories are based on the audience’s behaviour or the way in which they are influenced. In this unit, we shall deal with various aspects of the audience and its theories and try to find the relationship between audience, communicators, channels, and content. The emphasis is on the audience and its relationship with the message or the content. The way media policies and the content impacts the audience are some key issues discussed in this unit.

15.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After learning from this unit you should be able to:

- discuss the concept of audience in mass media;
- analyse the way in which the audience becomes a market;
- examine key audience theories and their characteristics;
- describe interactive audience; and
- explain and apply audience theories in your own work.

15.2 CONCEPT OF AUDIENCE

An audience, as you are aware, is a group of people who participate in a show of art, literature (readers), theatre, music (listeners), video games (players) in any medium. A media audience may be as small as one person reading a newspaper or magazine or billions of people watching world events over television.

Historically, audience was a different concept; perhaps it would be people reading newspapers/ books/ magazines. After films arrived it was a group of people watching cinema in the theatres. But the invention of Radio and later TV, changed the concept of audience. The groups or individuals became a split audience of groups or could be an individual audience. Radio could be listened to by a group of people anywhere in the world altogether. The technological advancement at times have added another dimension to the concept of audience. For instance, the video games available online separates the audience. However, there is also another side to it, programmes on TV watched together by people all over the world, bring all of them together.

15.2.1 Origin of the Audience

Origin of the audience can be traced back to a group of people sitting together behind an imaginary line watching performers of any kind. The first such audience came up during theatres, which began as a ritual, with tribal dances and festivals celebrating the harvest, marriages, Gods and basically any other event that warranted a party in villages. It was a participatory kind of theatre where the performers would be joined by villagers. Many of these kind of audience are still found in Asia and India.

The first recorded audience came from Greece (4th and 5th Century BC) where villagers celebrated harvest by invoking Gods. In this kind of audience, seats were reserved according to one's status; (though free) the rich got front row elaborate seats, while the peasants and other lower class were seated at the back. The Romans took the idea of 'Spectator' a little further to a lively audience. In Asia, theatre developed through agricultural festival.

It becomes clear to understand through the definitions of audience who are a group of listeners or spectators. The origin could be a music concert that made people listen to music while also watching them sing. Audience are a group of ardent admirers; theatre audience admitting performers.

Over the years, it has been noted that audience can be friendly, apathetic, uninformed or hostile. For each of these audiences, the communicator needs to

have different approaches. For friendly – you have to reinforce their beliefs; Apathetic – convince them that it matters to them; uninformed – educate them before proposing a course of action; Hostile – respect them and their viewpoint.

15.2.2 Defining Mass Audience

Before defining Mass Audience, one needs to revisit the concept of 'Mass'. As earlier discussed, according to Blumer's Mass Communication Theory, Mass is heterogeneous, large, and anonymous. Heterogeneity of mass refers to different classes of people; they can be of different demographics of age, gender, income, religion and of different vocations or areas. A representative of mass can be either in India or in USA; it's a large number, probably unidentifiable, anonymous and unknown.

Theorising, Mass audience, we can infer that when people watch a film or read a magazine at home, they become part of a 'Mass audience'; everyone who experiences a media text becomes part of a mass audience of that text. This is like a FIFA World Cup crowd at the match, all watching the same game, but with media, the audience are separated by distance and time.

Since the mass is very large in size and in physical terms, the people are distinguished all over, they are anonymous to each other. They are not aware of one another. Since the people are anonymous, the masses are unorganised. Unlike a public meeting, the masses do not have a common goal to achieve. Further, the masses are not capable of behaving as one unit.

There are four different ways of understanding the concept of mass audiences:

Media Reach: It refers to the reach of every media; the newspapers/ magazine readers; the radio listeners; the TV viewers; with the new media it could be the netizens.

Media Access: Mass media may be available but the capacity or willingness to use it, is the access; newspapers may be available, but masses may not read it;

Media Exposure: In fact, many members of the mass may not be exposed to the new media technology or other mainstream media. In addition, no one is exposed to the total content of any medium. Yet all users of media content are not uniformly exposed.

Media Effects: Another factor of media audience is whether the audience has undergone any change in knowledge, attitude, and behaviour due to media exposure.

15.2.3 Audience as Market

During the early days of mass media, especially the print media, the function of journalism was to serve as a social institution and Fourth Estate of Democracy. Growth and technological development of the mass media changed the entire scenario; in the present context, media is a multibillion dollar industry with the major aim of profit making. Commercialisation of the media has made the audience into a market. The media content is a commodity that is served with all the required ingredients to the consumer/ audience. Profit being the main goal, competition between producers has increased. Audience, according to market

concept, can be defined as an aggregate of potential consumers with a known socio-economic profile at which medium or message is directed.

As a consumer concept, audience has a dual importance i.e. for content and for advertising. Advertising is the largest source of revenue for the media. Profits are directed by the advertisements – as a result the more the advertisements in newspapers and more commercials in TV, or jingles in Radio, the more the profits. Competition driven media, targets to get more ad revenue. Hence, the content of the media is often decided by the advertisers as the lure of the revenue changes the policies of the media. In this unholy nexus, the audience assumes the role of a market.

Audiences only exist as an imaginary entity, an abstraction, constructed from the vantage point of institution, in the interest of the institution. Audience is not just about their demographics such as gender, age, social class, but rather about psychographics such as their hobbies, habits and interests. In this context, the core concept of the audience theory depends on Genre, Narrative, Representation, Audience, Media Language.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Explain the concept of audience.

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2) Define 'Mass Audience'

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15.3 KEY AUDIENCE THEORIES

The audience theories are generally based on why audience choose certain texts, how do they consume these texts / contents and what happens when they consume information to context.

There are three key theories of audience:

- 1) Hypodermic Needle Theory
- 2) Uses and Gratification theory
- 3) Reception theory

You have read these theories in detail in other units; here we shall briefly recapitulate their salient points in relation to the topic under discussion.

15.3.1 Hypodermic Needle Theory

The Effects theory or the Hypodermic Needle Theory which is described as a 'Magic bullet' is said to be the media content that reaches the audience directly like a syringe pricking the body and producing an impact. This is similar to the Psychology theory of 'Stimulus - Response'.

The consumption of the media texts has an influence upon the audience. Audiences are passive and powerless to prevent the influence. The power lies with the message of the text. Therefore the media works like a drug and the audience is drugged, addicted, doped or even duped.

In fact, the Frankfurt School theorised as early as in 1920s and 30s that the media controlled the audiences to the benefits of capitalists and Government. The other important study that proved the Hypodermic Needle Model in 1963 was that of Bobo Doll by Albert Bandura which apparently proved that children who watch violence in TV programme turn out to be violent.

15.3.2 Gratification Set as Audience

Audience as a gratification set is different from that of Hypodermic Needle Model; and this audience decides what to do with the media rather than the media directly influencing the audience. The audience seeks the media for gratifying a need. They seek the message (what they want) from the media to interpret it. The audience here is subjective and choosy.

This is an audience that wants information to keep itself informed (on the kind of information needed); for the sake of identifying itself (personal identity); diversion from stress, boredom, relief (escapism); to relate to characters in TV programmes.

Gratification may also lead to media dependency. The more the individual / audience uses media to gratify their needs, the more independent the audience becomes; the media influence will increase over the audience.

15.3.3 Reception Theory

According to Effects model, media produces inactivity, makes us 'couch potatoes', students do not study and hence get no jobs; the media also leads to violence as viewing violent programmes impacts the viewers; media also includes 'copy cat behaviour' and advertisements in media brings about mindless and unwanted shopping and so on. Stuart Hall (1973) claims that there are three ways in which the audience responds to content:

- a) **Preferred/ Dominant readings:** The producer provides the same kind of text that the audience requires according to their socio-cultural background and in such a case, the audience has little to challenge.
- b) **Negotiate readings:** In this case, the audience may not agree fully with the context but tries to adjust to what is written/ viewed so that they get the maximum out of what they read/ view.
- c) **Opposition/ Resistant readings:** The audience resists the context read/ viewed as the content may be socio-culturally against the values the viewers behold.

15.3.4 Types of Audience

The types of audiences can be distinguished based on their demographic characteristic and mental makeup;

- 1) **Elite Audience:** Elite audiences are composed of the people who are decision-makers and trendsetters in the society. They are economically well to do and are highly educated. They have high status in the society. Their number is very small but their influence is very strong. They may also be the owners or controllers of the mass media institutions. The members of the elite audiences are the early adopters of communication technologies. Their actual media consumption is generally low.
- 2) **General Audiences:** They are very large and highly diverse groups that represent the broad cross-section of the society. Majority of the people belong to this category. The media content is generally targeted to them. Their participation determines the success or failure of a content or medium.
- 3) **Special Interest Audiences:** These audiences are composed of individuals who possess similar characteristics. They are relatively small in number. Mass media generate special contents for these audience groups. Programmes for tribals, housewives, college students, etc. are examples of programmes for special interest audiences. Similarly, journals like *Mainstream*, *Economic and Political Weekly*, *Media Asia* have limited but known readership.

Social Group or Public

A Social group can start right from a family. A family get-together at a function or an event like an engagement becomes a bigger social group. Hence, we have social gatherings at major events like marriages, parties or even an elite group of people meeting at a charity function. Moreover, all these groups do have a common cause.

In a small group, all members know each other. They are aware of their common membership, share the same values, have a certain structure of relationships. They interact with one another for a common cause. The larger the group the greater is the difficulty to interact.

The social groups as target audience are relatively easy to handle. Because, one can understand and study the social group and know their needs and wants. Producers can make such programmes and treat them as a single homogenous audience.

Publics are widely dispersed. They may be small or large. Generally public is identified with some cause, purpose or activity. Public may be heterogeneous and members may not know each other. Political parties treat members of social groups as public when information about their policies and plans are disseminated. Publics as target audiences are difficult to persuade and motivate as they are heterogeneous.

Medium Audience

Mass media has a diversified audience and each medium has its own audience. Mass communication via media reaches a mass audience. Print media

disseminates information to readers through newspapers. The broadcast media informs masses electronically. Radio is a listener's medium; TV is an audiovisual media; film is also an audiovisual medium. The New Communication Technology involves reading, listening and watching.

Mainstream media audiences who were very popular earlier have now been redefined owing to digital technology. Moreover, the media audiences now have been fragmented. The fragmentation has led to smaller audiences for each media. The major chunk of media audience belongs to the broadcast media. These audiences usually consume sitcoms and soaps.

The other media audience is the 'Niche Audience', which prefers unique programmes or read only custom content. These in fact, are a small group of audience. The media/ medium audiences belong to different classes and categories. This categorisation can be according to professions, social classes and others.

Channel and Content Audience

Audience can be a set, group, or mass of people who use particular media or channels for some content of messages / information at a particular time. The channel or Content Audience is like the Gratification set audience.

Based on the needs and interests of the audience, they can be classified into audience created and media created audiences.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Briefly explain the following:

a) Social groups

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b) Public

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c) Gratification set

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15.4 STRUCTURE OF AUDIENCE THEORIES

The basic structure of audience theories is the effect produced on the audience. The SMCR model is the fundamental theory to understand the structure of audience theories. All the elements in the process of communication have an effect, either direct or indirect on the audience. Berlo's Model of Communication clearly indicates as to how each element of the communication process is interrelated and impact each other and also the audience.

15.4.1 Structural Model of Media Use

In 1969, Jay Blumer and McQuail studied the 1964 election in UK by examining motives for watching certain political programmes on TV. McQuail's Structural Model implies categorising the needs of viewers or the audience's needs to view the programme. In other words, McQuail's Structural Model of media usage suggests that Media use by audience has a 'Structure' and the structure can be categorised into various 'needs'.

In 1972, Denis McQuail, Jay Blumer and Joseph Brown suggested that the uses of different types of media can be grouped into four categories i.e. diversion, personal relationship, personal identity and surveillance. Blumer, McQuail and other theorists made clear their belief that people's use of media and their gratification they seek from it are inextricably intertwined with the world which they live. In 1974, they wrote that 'Social Situations' in which people find themselves can be 'involved in the generation of media related needs' in five ways:

- Social structures can produce tensions and conflicts leading to consumption of media to care the same;
- Social situations can create an awareness of problems that demands attention, information which can be obtained from the media;
- Social situation can impoverish real-life opportunities to satisfy certain needs, and the media can serve as substitutes;
- Social situations often elicit specific values and then affirmation can be facilitated through media;
- Social situations demand familiarity with the media; these demands can be met by the media;

Media structure refers to the relatively constant array of channels; choice of content that is available in a given place and time.

15.4.2 Expectancy – Value Model of Media Gratification

Uses and Gratification Approach discussed in Unit 3 is relevant to the study of Audience Theory. It will not be discussed here but you will have to include UGT while answering any question on Audience Theory.

Expectancy – Value Theory is directly linked to Uses and Gratification Theory. This theory was propounded by Martin Fishbein in 1970. According to this theory, behaviour is a function of the 'expectancies' one has and the 'value' of the good toward which one is working. Such an approach predicts that, when more than

one behaviour is possible, the behaviour chosen will be the one with the largest combination of expected success value.

The social influence of the audience in particular impacts attitude and attitude change. Media gratification is because of the social influence of the audience. Audience seeks particular media content due to their attitude developed because of social influence. This theory has also evolved as a refined tool in various fields such as advertising, education etc. For instance, the social influence on a particular brand of garments may make the audience look for commercials on TV for that specific brand and develop an attitude to buy the product.

According to Fishbein (EVT/ Mode), first, individuals respond to information about an object (obtained invariably from the media) or behaviour by developing a belief about it. If the belief already exists (for ex: Organic foods are food for health) it may be modified by new information (characteristics of organic foods). Next, individuals assign a value to each attribute 'that' a belief is based on (organic food help in making you healthy). Finally, an expectation is created or modified based on the circulation of beliefs and values (to buy the newly brought out organic food advertised).

15.4.3 Integrated Model of Audience Choice

Dennis McQuail (2000:391) refers to this model which was influenced by Webster and Wakshlag (1983). This model integrates audience and media variables and gives audience perspective as well as media perspective. The following factors explain the two sides:

Audience Factor

- 1) Media selection is influenced by Social background, especially social class, education, religion, culture, political environment and family and the location of residence.
- 2) Personal attributes like age, gender, family position, education, profession, income, and lifestyle play a role in media choice.
- 3) Personal choices of media content depend on genres, formats, specific content.
- 4) General habits of media use in leisure time and other time availability matter.
- 5) Awareness in choosing the amount and type of information is a factor where active audiences can be expected to plan their own media usage that you appreciate for them.

Media Factor

- 1) Media system (the members, range and type of media available) specific characteristics of various media channels – national, local, language, formats influences audience attention.
- 2) Structure of media refers to the general pattern of whether the media provides to the community what information they expect.
- 3) Content availability that plays a role with specific formats and genres offered to a potential audience.

- 4) Media publicity or promotional programmes refer to advertising and image development by the media for their own interests.
- 5) Time and attendance – selection and use of media are influenced by specific strategies of time, schedule, and design of content in accordance with the competition strategy to get the audience. For instance – most regional language TV channels air the same formats and programmes at the same time to beat competition.

These factors indicate the integrated approach where the audience and media are interdependent.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) Briefly explain the structural Model of Media Use by Dennis McQuail.

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- 2) What is 'Expectancy Value of Media'?

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15.5 MEDIA AND AUDIENCE

Media and Audience are major elements of the communication process. The content providers are the media for the audience who are the receivers. A media audience may be as small as one person (a single person watching TV or reading a newspaper) or as large as billions or infinite number of people around the world watching events or programmes anywhere, anytime in the world. For media producers, the audience is very important because without an audience there would be no media. It is important for media as they are the ones, which make them competitive, profitable, and to be in business.

The audiences are active but they can be primary or secondary and they can be single or a mass as well. They can be a large group or fragmented and with the development of technology, they can be interactive.

15.5.1 Audience Fragmentation

With the advancement of media technology, the availability of media outlets have increased three folds. Audience fragmentation refers to division of audiences into different groups (small or big) due to the wide spectrum of media channels.

Audience fragmentation can be also considered as a process of dividing people into homogeneous subgroups based on defined criterion such as demographics,

communication behaviour, media use, etc. For instance, age group of youth and senior citizen could be a fragmentation. Audience can be grouped as per the media usage – TV viewers, Netizens, FM listeners etc. In case of newspapers readership, a further fragmentation of audiences can be those who read hardcopy and those who read e-papers online.

The crux of audience fragmentation is due to media convergence. The same media content is available in all media. If you read a news report in newspaper, the same is found in e-paper, and also appears at once in social media sites in brief even before the next morning's paper. Audience fragmentation has led to problems for the advertisers, because they have to cater to the audience of different kinds, locations, at the same time.

Digital technology has led to an increasing uncertainty over audiences, as large number of people are reading/ viewing the same content probably at the same time or different time. Audience fragmentation plays a vital role in technology. Narrowcasting which is the opposite of broadcasting reaches smaller audiences with specialised Cable TV whereas 'Zone casting' in technology delivers different commercials to specific neighbourhoods, and location based mobile advertising is technology which follows you around to sell things 24x7.

Activity-1

Collect data on the reach of different media for five years, prepare a table and trace the audience fragmentation during this period.

15.5.2 Interactive Audience

As you are aware, the interactive media normally refers to products and services on digital computer based systems which respond to the users actions by presenting content such as text, moving images, animation, video, audio and video games. Systems enabling large audiences to interact offer numerous possibilities for entertainment, education and information. Interactive media creates graphics and animations for various media outlets, electronic gadgets such as mobile phones applications, web based computer games, or interactive websites.

The main characteristic of interactive audience is that they respond to the digital input. Traditional media such as print or broadcast involves an audience reading or watching with no way to navigate. In 1990s with the commercialisation of Internet, an interactive audience replaced the one-way communication. The common kinds of interactive audience include the following:

- **Application Software** – Software developed for knowledge management platform; for instance, if you want to know 'How to keep pests away' – this application will help you.
- **Apps** – the most popular form of interactive media/ audience, Zomato, Swiggy – interact and place in order.
- **Games** – interactive games and activities are ideas for groups/ individual audience (s). A number of interactive games are available in the digital platform; Family Tree, Little thief, etc.

- **Interactive Video** – Video and TV with interactive features such as Video/TV streaming; you can live stream programmes and interact.
- **Social Media** – the major chunk of interactive audience forms the social media or SNS digital communities that allow media to be navigated, shared and created, eg: YouTube.
- **Advertising** – digital, outdoor and in-store advertising that features interactive elements such as a digital poster that reacts to people who are in its proximity.

All of above are popular forms of interactive media with a dense population of interactive audiences, all over the world.

15.5.3 Audience Research

Audience Research is conducted on any specific audience segments to gather, analyse and interpret information obtained on their attitudes, knowledge, interest, behaviour and preferences on particular issues/ events. It is generally conducted to understand the audience the media caters to. Advertisers want to know what are the needs of the audience, how they react to a product, how by knowing the audience needs, they can improvise the product, how to motivate and persuade the audience to buy the product.

Audience have different demographic categories namely income, gender, profession, marital status, and religion. Audience research can be of different formats like surveys with questionnaires, market research online forums, interviews and focus groups.

Audience research is advantageous as it can find out the likes and dislikes of the audience and one can find important information about the channel content. It is used to create an audience profile and will help in defining target audience. However, the research is time consuming and can be costly where questions can be biased, and hence results can be invalid if responses are vague or incomplete.

Surveys are conducted to find out the readership of newspapers and magazines, listenership of Radio and viewership of TV and films. TV viewership research is conducted for Ratings (TV Rating Points – TRP). Research has gained momentum in case of Internet and Social Media, the need, the outcome are made to understand the increase in popularity of the New Media. Digital media usage especially smart phones have become highly popular in Audience Research methods. You will read in detail about research in the Course MJM-031 Communication Research Methods.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is audience fragmentation?

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2) What is audience research?

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15.6 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we discussed various aspects of ‘Audience’ or the receiver who constitutes one of the most important elements of communication process. For a communicator, the receiver or the target audience is most important because for an effective communication, the feedback from the audience is always required.

Media audience is a large number of people who are scattered or even a single individual or a group. Historically, audience could be just a reader of a newspaper or magazine but the invention of Radio changed this concept.

The origin of audience is traced to ancient days where villages celebrated harvest festival. Mass audiences are those which are large, heterogeneous and anonymous. A representative of mass can be in India, USA or Australia. The concept of mass audience depends on Media Reach, Media Access, Media Exposure, and Media Effects.

Media is presently a profit making industry and audience is the market where media content is sold to the buyers (audience). The key audience theories are Effects Theory, UGT and Reception theory. The Effects theory is the ‘Magic Bullet’ or Stimulus Response where the media produces an immediate effect and there is a reaction from the audience.

Social group as an audience is easy to handle because one understands the characteristics of a group as it is more or less homogeneous compared to a public. However, publics are identified with a cause or activity. The Gratification set as audience is the opposite of the Hypodermic Needle Model audience as this audience decides what to do with the media rather than what media does to it.

Every medium has its own audiences. A channel and content audience is like the gratification set audience who depend on a particular channel and particular content. For instance, color TV for a particular sitcom.

Audience is fragmented because of different media availability. The audience hence develops their likes towards particular media depending on various factors like content structure, time, format, speed etc. The new type of interactive audience is the most popular kind all over the world especially by the younger generation. Audience Research is conducted to understand the needs and wants of the audience and is considered necessary by the ever blooming profit oriented media organisations in order to meet the competition.

15.7 FURTHER READINGS

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Sullivan, John L (2012). *Media Audiences: Effects, Users, Institutions, and Power*. New Delhi; Sage Publications.

15.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) An audience is a group of people who participate in a show of art, literature (readers), theatre, music (listeners), video games (players) in any medium. Audience is a group of listeners or spectators.
- 2) Mass audience can be defined as a set of people who experiences a media text even if separated by distance and by time. Since the mass is very large in size and in physical terms, the people are anonymous to each other and are unorganised. They do not have a common goal to achieve and are not capable of behaving as one unit.

Check Your Progress 2

- a) Social groups can be small or big – mostly having a common cause. In a small group, all members know each other, have a certain structure of relationships and interact with one another for a common cause. The larger the group the greater is the difficulty to interact. The social groups as target audience are relatively easy to handle because, one can understand and study the social group and know their needs and wants. Producers can make such programme and treat them as a single homogenous audience.
- b) Publics are widely dispersed – they may be small or large and generally have a cause, purpose, or activity. Public may be heterogeneous and members may not know each other hence as target audiences are difficult to persuade and motivate.
- c) Audience as a gratification set decides what to do with the media rather than the media does to the audience. This audience is subjective, choosy and seeks the media for gratifying a need. However, gratification may also lead to media dependency as more the audience uses media to gratify their needs, the more independent the audience may become.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) The Structural Model of media usage suggests that Media use by audience has a 'Structure' and the structure can be categorised into various 'needs'.

- 2) Expectancy – value Model behaviour is the function of the ‘expectations’ one has, and the ‘value’ of the goal towards which, one is working. The ‘Integrated Model of Audience Choice’ is based on both the sides of audience and media.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) Audience fragmentation refers to the division of audiences into different groups (small or big) due to the wide spectrum of media channels. It is a process of dividing people into homogeneous sub-groups based on some specific criterion such as demographics, communication behaviour, media use, etc.
- 2) Audience Research is conducted on any specific audience segment to gather, analyse and interpret information obtained on their attitudes, knowledge, interest, behaviour and preferences on particular issues and events.



UNIT 16 FEMINIST MEDIA THEORIES

Structure

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16.3.1 Feminism and Intersectionality: Gender, Caste, and Class

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16.0 INTRODUCTION

Feminist Media Studies draws on feminist theory to study and research media content, processes, and organisations. It helps us understand some of these concepts identified by feminist scholars, to analyse how media manifest gender biases in production, distribution, and audience reception of media representation in entertainment and news. Some concepts that are used in the context of feminist media studies are Standpoint Theory (Harding, 1991), Intersectionality, Performativity (Butler, 1990), the Public/Private Debate, and the Notion of the Cyborg (Haraway, 1991).

In this unit, we shall discuss about some of the foundational feminist media theories and see how they can be used to better understand issues of the role of media in constructing gender and how new media technologies can both reinforce and challenge traditional gender roles.

16.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After working through this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss women-centered research;

- distinguish feminist empiricism from feminist standpoint theory;
- analyse media texts in respect of politics of representation;
- describe how media production and consumption patterns can be analysed from a feminist perspective;
- examine various issues related to digital cultures, gender, and society; and
- apply feminist media theory in your research work.

16.2 WOMEN-CENTRED RESEARCH

In order to understand the meaning and value of feminist media theories in the field of communication, we must first take a look at the history of the feminist movement and the gradual growth of feminist perspectives within research environments. In the following sections, we will first see how feminists became interested in the role of media with regard to women's issues, and how feminist theory began to be used to analyse media content. We will then look at how feminist media theory studies the politics of representation, media production, and audience reception. Finally, we shall see how digital cultures have contributed to the way women are represented in the media, intensifying the problems rather than improving them. Yet, there is hope as feminist media scholars, activists, and ordinary users are battling these issues at every level.

16.2.1 Growth and Development of the Field

Feminist media research has come a long way since its beginnings in the 1970s. Earlier research focused on under representation to women in media and stereotyping of women. Early feminist research focused more on Freudian psychoanalytic theory on the role gender in positioning the audience in relation to media content. More research has been done in the past on the role of media in reinforcing patriarchal ideology to suppress women. Gradually, gender research has made advances by drawing heavily from Feminist theory and feminist research. Today, gender research has a new approach and is examining how media are related to gender by underlining the concept gender construction.

Some scholars point to Betty Frieden's influential book, *The Feminine Mystique* (1963) as being among the first strongly feminist critiques of the mass media in the West. The United Nations International Decade for Women (1975 to 1985) and UNESCO-sponsored reports during the same period also brought an international focus to the many manifestations of women's issues, and highlighted the media as a particular source of women's oppression (Gallagher, 2003).

Over the last several decades, feminist media research has undergone many shifts and changes. Media are gendered is the new approach to the study of feminist media studies.

16.2.2 Feminist Empiricism and Development of Standpoint Theory

Feminist sociologist Dorothy Smith (1987) highlighted the structural inequities in a social system that excluded women and called for sociological inquiry that saw women, not as objects of study, but as active subjects. She argued that the everyday lives of women should be studied, and their experiences taken into

account in research. This inquiry would be from the “standpoint of women” and did not imply a common viewpoint among women, but a common or shared experience of exclusion in society.

Other feminist theorists also emphasised taking into account the experiences of women from their own viewpoint as an important way to build new areas of knowledge that had previously been ignored. Sandra Harding (1991) described and named two different feminist approaches to research: feminist empiricism and feminist standpoint theory.

Feminist empiricism is an approach that critiqued traditional research models and methods as sexist. Applied primarily in fields such as biology and social sciences, the scholars advocating this approach argued that women and gender issues are excluded from scientific inquiry at all levels. While this approach identifies the exclusion of women from research agenda, it does not call for a change in the methods of research; rather, it emphasises the need to apply the rules of empirical research to gender research. It means that feminist research should be empirical based on observation and experience. Feminist empiricism draws attention to bias in currently accepted scientific methods of research. This approach argues that feminist values, social and political factors should be subjected to scientific enquiry.

Feminist standpoint theory on the other hand, argues for a research agenda based on the perspectives of women themselves. Harding (1991) and others point out that women’s experiences are a valuable source of knowledge, and we need to take into consideration the viewpoints of women and their accounts of their experiences. Women’s different lives have been erroneously devalued and neglected as starting points for scientific research and as the generators of evidence for or against knowledge claims...human lives are not homogenous in any gender-stratified society. Women and men are assigned different kinds of activities in such societies; consequently, they lead lives that have significantly different contours and patterns (1991:121).

There are several Feminist Standpoint theories including Marxist feminist standpoint theory. Thus, standpoint theory is a type of critical theory which intends to empower women to project true representation of women to enable the oppressors to understand women’s issues in a more scientific point of view rather than being philosophical. It represents an approach that requires us to place women, their experiences, and their perspectives as central to the research process. Feminist media scholars have also adopted this standpoint theory approach and see it as essential in working towards a more gender-sensitised and equitable media environment.

16.2.3 Political Dimension: Researcher or Activist?

Within the feminist movement, there has always been a ‘push and pull’ relationship between activism and research. Feminist theory developed in the context of the women’s movement; as women took to the streets to fight for their rights, they also wrote about the reasons for women’s oppression, the many ways in which it manifested, and what could be done about it. So, from the beginning, there were two approaches to the issue: one that sought to understand it intellectually and write about it, and another that looked for action-oriented ways to make a difference. Despite changes in the focus of the movement and research,

both approaches have as their agenda a foundational goal towards overturning women's subjugation and make them equal citizens in society.

Over the decades, media theory, due to its inherently interdisciplinary nature, has expanded and drawn from different kinds of theoretical traditions, including literary criticism, linguistics and film studies. Feminist media theory has been somewhat unique as it has retained at its core an essential political agenda that seeks to bring about change in the status of women worldwide. Towards this goal, it works to highlight and fight against institutional inequities in media and society, as well as social and cultural biases about gender and sexuality in media representations. In doing so, it blurs the boundaries between activism and research, between journalist, scholar, and activist.

Feminist media theory takes a three-pronged approach to research:

- 1) Media content from all genres to study the politics of representation
- 2) Media processes and institutions that exclude women
- 3) Media consumption, and evaluating audience perception

The following sections will introduce you to some of the theories that underpin these research goals.

Activity-1

Select a research journal of your choice and go through its content. Identify the research papers published on gender issues and analyse their focus and approach in terms of the three approaches outlined above. Analyse what topics of research are chosen and why?

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) How feminist media research is different from traditional feminist research?

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- 2) What is the difference between feminist empiricism and feminist standpoint theory?

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16.3 MEDIA TEXTS: POLITICS OF REPRESENTATION

As the importance of studying media from a feminist perspective became clear, feminist media scholars focused on expanding the categories of study within the field of communication. They began to study themes, content and topics that were previously considered a women's domain and not worthy of serious study. They sought to reintroduce women, their issues, and perspectives into the research agenda, where before they were gender-blind. Through the hard work of feminist media theorists, "women's genres" such as soap operas, daytime television, romance fiction, and magazines were studied and issues such as domestic violence, objectification of women through language and images, standards of beauty, and pornography slowly became legitimate topics of study.

16.3.1 Feminism and Intersectionality: Gender, Caste, and Class

Within the larger field of feminism, western feminists' approach of emphasising commonality (of women's oppression) over difference began to be questioned by non-white/ non-western women. Feminist theory, especially in the 70s and 80s tended to emphasise commonality over difference, the shared experience of oppression by women the world over. The feminist movement – both activist and academic sought to push through these barriers in order to make women's issues more visible, and women's voices heard.

By the late 80s and early 90s, African American and Hispanic scholars began to call for rejecting the commonality view, insisting instead on recognising multiplicity and Intersectionality of experience. Black legal scholar Kimberlie Crenshaw coined the term, "intersectionality" in 1989 which manages to encompass in a single word the simultaneous experience of the multiple oppressions faced by women because of race or gender making women's oppression heterogenous. .

White feminists were criticised for characterising women's oppression as a monolithic and homogenous phenomenon. Non-white feminists began to argue that the traditional approach normalised white, Christian, western, hetero-normative, middle-class women's perspectives as standard, while ignoring the vast differences in experiences that women from different contexts and positions would have. Thus, standpoint theorists came to recognise that it would be inaccurate to claim a universal standpoint for women. Barbara Smith, Black feminist and scholar explains, "Women are variously located in society. Their situations are much more various than the topics we recognise somewhat stereotypically as women's topics would suggest... Even among housewives, who appear to share a universal fate, there are rather wider differences in the conditions, practices, and organisation of housework and the social relations in which it is embedded than our studies and the ways in which they have been framed would allow" (1987:85-86).

Non-western feminists speak up

Feminist media theorists also began to focus on women's issues taking care to recognise the multiplicity of experiences and therefore a multiplicity of voices. Thus, we can understand **intersectionality** as interrelated social, cultural, and

economic institutional systems of power that can be oppressive to marginalised groups; this framework recognises multiple standpoints of experience and reminds us not to privilege one over another.

In India, early work in the area of feminist media theory came from fields not necessarily in the traditional field of communication. For instance, Tharu and Lalita (1991) wrote about the erasure of women's voices in the context of literature and writing. The authors Susie Tharu and K.Lakita have worked to "recover", compile and publish, Indian women's writing in multiple Indian languages since 600 BC to early 20th century. This is a collection of Indian women's works reflecting not only the literary tradition but also social text of the marginalised voices of women written during different periods of history.

Another important work in the field of feminist media is by journalists and activists Joseph and Sharma (1994, 2006), who analysed and critiqued press coverage of five different women's issues – dowry deaths, rape, sati, the use of amniocentesis for sex determination, and the right to alimony for Muslim women - and the portrayal of women on television in India. The longitudinal study over 10 years is landmark in its gathering and presenting of data to show the selective portrayal of women in media.

16.3.2 The Public/Private Dichotomy

Media have marginalised women in 'public sphere'. An important area of work in feminist theory has been the debate about the public sphere versus the private sphere. How can we understand what it means and how it marginalises women? Historically, this binary emerged when developing nation-states in medieval Europe began to define certain areas - such as government, policy, law, and citizenship – as part of the public sphere. As a counterbalance, men of the ruling class created a "private" sphere to protect personal aspects such as religious beliefs and family issues from state control. Thus the terms "public" and "private" began to be used to refer to the distinction between state and society and to the distinction between non-domestic and domestic spheres. Women, in their capacity as daughters and wives, and within the context of their domestic spaces, were thus relegated to the private sphere and systematically discouraged and/or eliminated from taking part in the public realm. Further, this binary of public and private began to be seen as relating almost exclusively to the worlds of men and women and now tends to be portrayed as universal, biological, and natural.

Feminist theorists see this dichotomy as problematic and have sought to overturn it, arguing that this artificial separation works to maintain men's authority over women's bodies and labour. By keeping issues of sexuality, family, and women's labour in the private sphere, women's contributions to economy and society are minimised, marginalised and delegitimised. Habermas's concept of "Public Sphere" relates to the practice in ancient Greek where men engaged in discussion of politics in public sphere and private sphere meant family and home life. Naturally, women were pushed automatically into private sphere keeping them out of political realm of public sphere. The feminist movement has sought to dismantle this divide by showing that in fact "domestic, private" issues are actually shaped by "public" factors of politics and power.

In India, Sangari and Vaid (1989) trace the increasing enforcement of this divide in the context of the nationalist movement and a consequence of Victorian and

colonial ideas that were prevalent in India during the 18th and 19th centuries. These efforts moved women more and more into a private, domestic sphere, banishing them from public spaces by framing it as a privilege and patriotic duty of upper and middle class women. Again, while one must remember that a woman's experience of the private sphere depends on her location (caste, class, religion, etc.) within society, *all* women are subject to the norms of this imposed binary. The work done by Phadke, Khan, & Ranade (2009) with regard to women's access to public spaces in India has provided us with a contemporary framework of understanding the public and private lives of Indian women in the context of women's freedom of assertion in public space.

“The personal is the political”

The feminist critique of the public/private dichotomy is also connected to the popular feminist slogan “the personal is the political.” Menon (2012) explains how the two realms constantly merge and blur in the context of Indian society. She identifies the patriarchal, heterosexual family structure as implicit in maintaining women's secondary status in society.

This dichotomy has played out in media and communication studies as a division between supposedly gender-neutral topics like citizenship and policy and “women's topics” such as domestic violence, pornography, daytime television, soap operas etc. While these topics began to be studied within the field, these streams of research nevertheless remained separate from mainstream focus of topics such as news and politics, and a “blind spot in feminist media criticism” (Van Zoonen, 1994). But as the field progressed, the larger feminist movement's focus on the politics of representation, the structures of power, and systems of knowledge production that discriminate against women, became a focus for feminist media theorists too.

16.3.3 Role of Media is Constructing Gender and Identity

There are gender norms associated with men's and women's spheres and women are often policed and criticised when they act outside of these norms. This public vs private divide with regard to behaviour can be seen in the way women politicians, or sports women are portrayed in the media. The images of sportswoman in media are more body focused than action oriented. A sportswoman may be asked questions about her family while her male counterpart is not asked about technical issues of the sport. Similarly, a female politician may be described as loud, aggressive, or having masculine qualities, and her clothes, make-up, and looks commented on unlike for a man in the same field.

For example, research has shown how female politicians like Hillary Clinton are treated differently and held to different standards of competence, behaviour, and physical appearance. This research shows that while a man's competence in a professional field are highlighted, a woman politician tends to be questioned about her family and her work is positioned as a conflict between her role as a mother and a professional. Similarly studies have shown how women politicians (e.g. Media Monitoring Project, 1999) continue to be portrayed differently from their male counterparts.

In sports, tennis player Serena Williams has faced lots of discrimination for her behaviour, appearance, and playing style and newspaper editorials have

commented on the racialised, gender discrimination she is subject to on a regular basis. Indian tennis player, Sania Mirza has also faced similar discrimination by the media. These instances also remind us of the intersectionality of experience, as well as how entrenched the public/private divide is - as Serena's gender and race are implicated in the discrimination, while in the case of Sania, she has received criticism for transgressing the behavioural expectations of an Indian Muslim woman.

Once popular culture forms of media became legitimate areas of study, feminist and critical theories were used to analyse the objectification of women in genres such as music videos, magazine advertising, pornography, talk shows. Some of the topics of interest studied in this area are: sex and advertising, representation of non-whites in advertising, film, and television, and representation of domestic violence and victimhood in media content.

Some early works in India include scholarship on nationhood, television and women (2000) by P. Mankekar and South Indian cinema and female stars (2000) by T. Niranjana, while newer work looks at Indian issues, but often with a global perspective. For example, R. Hegde and R. Parameswaran are some scholars who have looked at the representations of Indian women in global context and the politics of western standards of beauty. Some documentary filmmakers and members of the Mediastorm Collective continue to use feminist concepts and ideas in films.

Activity - 2

Choose three television shows that you think can be studied from a feminist perspective. You could choose a game show, a TV serial, or music competition. Can you apply any feminist media theory to analyse the show?

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What does intersectionality mean?

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2) List some genres of media content that have been studied from a feminist perspective.

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16.4 MEDIA PRODUCTION AND CONSUMPTION

Even as feminist media theorists began to focus on the signs and symbols of representation, political economy scholars were pointing out that studying systems

of representation were not enough, and that it was necessary to address the institutional and economic structure of power that worked to exclude women. The intense focus from representation began to shift to patterns of production and an interest in audience reception.

16.4.1 Dorothy Smith and Relations of Rule

Dorothy Smith (1987) was one of those early researchers who studied and identified the “relations of rule” that worked to exclude women from the supposedly public realm. By this she meant the institutional structures of society – including governance, policy, law, and economics – that were built and maintained exclusively by men, and specifically organised in such a way as to exclude women from these areas. Smith identifies the rise of capitalism and the emergence of an anonymous/impersonal marketplace of goods and ideas, as further pushing women to the margins – where men became solely in-charge of this expanded non-local sphere of operation, while women were limited to a hyper local, largely domestic sphere of functioning.

16.4.2 Media Production and Distribution

Political economy of media focuses on institutional structure of control and power and influences and defines what content the media produces and distributes. Feminist media scholars are studying ownership patterns and entrenched production process that discriminate against women in multiple ways through male-dominated leadership that excludes women from decision-making, information-gathering, content-producing positions within media production and distribution system.

For example, Steeves and Wasko address how economic imperatives, and political structures work not only to influence how women are represented in the media, but also how ownership patterns and media corporations exclude women professionals (2002). Sevanti Ninan, founding editor of India’s Hoot is also one of those who have focused attention on media houses and systems of ownership in India but it is still a developing field in India for researchers.

A current example of how media institutions exploit and suppress women and the way women are fighting back, is the #MeToo movement that emerged in the US over the course of 2017 and 2018. This is an instance of women finally calling out in public, the inherent misogyny of the media industries. Beginning with the revelation by multiple female actors in Hollywood that the powerful film producer Harvey Weinstein had sexually assaulted them and then used his power within the industry to ensure their silence, the #MeToo movement has spread to other areas of life, though notably the biggest scandals have come from media-related industries. Film directors, novelists, politicians, and judges have all been swept up in the wave as more and more women have stepped forward to show how women are controlled and manipulated in this male-dominated industry.

16.4.3 Women Consuming Media: Reception Studies

Along with looking at the way media represents women and women’s issues, and looking at the way institutional structures of power discriminate against women in the media production process, feminist media theorists are also interested in how audiences *consume* media content. The concept of the active

audience was developed in the Birmingham School by scholars such as Stuart Hall and Raymond Williams. While they focused on working class audience's reception of media content, feminist media scholars have used these ideas to see firstly what messages are people (both men and women) taking away from watching media, and secondly, how women consume media.

Research in this area is relatively scarcer than studies of representation. Nevertheless, many scholars have emphasised the importance of studying the context of consumption. Some topics of interest within this focus area are the study of women reader's consumption of romance fiction (1983) by Janice Radway; Ang's (1995) work on television fiction and women's fantasy, and research on the television talk show genre. P.Mankekar's ethnography of women television viewers in India (1999) is one among very few reception studies in the Indian context that takes a feminist perspective. There is a gap in this area of scholarship that offers many opportunities for research.

Activity-3

Follow the news (television or newspaper) for one week. What are the stories about women that are being reported? Find a story about the way women are exploited in media or entertainment industry and how women are fighting back.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) How can we apply Dorothy Smith's concept of "relations of rule" to studying media?

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2) Why is there less research on media consumption, than media representation?

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16.5 DIGITAL CULTURES, GENDER AND SOCIETY

Digital media, with the arrival of Web 2.0 have changed the very nature of what we used to call mass media. The ease of access, the interactivity, the all-pervasiveness, has all changed both the nature of the content, and the manner in which we consume it. Each one of us uses digital media in one way or another on a daily basis. Early predictions about digital/new media focused on the transformative powers of these technologies to democratise media, and scholars from many fields considered the ways that it could be used to give space and voice to marginalised groups. One would think that as the "spaces" for media

content have exponentially increased with digital platforms, quality, quantity, and representation would also improve. The study of digital cultures and social media has become a central focus for media scholars everywhere. For feminist media scholars, digital technologies and social media offer rich possibilities for research but increase in cyber harassment of women is matter of serious concern.

16.5.1 Performance and Portrayal of Self

Gender theorist Judith Butler (1990) uses the metaphor of the theatre and performance to describe human behaviour. She theorises that all humans behave based on the models of behaviour they are taught and that gender itself is a performance or an act that all people are actors who enact our gender roles repeatedly and thus turn it into reality. She views gender as a result of what we *do* and how we *behave*, rather than of what we *are*. She explains that gender is a cultural and societal construction that is enforced within the disciplinary framework of society and family, and that we are forced to perform the predetermined and stylised behaviours that through repetition become considered as natural, biological, or normal. She calls this **Performativity**. How can this theory be applied to media? On social media, we all “perform” our identity in various ways. The pictures we post, the people we choose to ‘friend’, the jokes and articles we share, all these make up our social media profile, and our personality. People, who may not know us in our “real” lives, may form an impression of who we are based on how we “perform” our self on social media.

Continuing our understanding of the self in cyberspace, Donna Haraway’s (1991) work on human-machine interaction and her notion of the cyborg as a “creature in a post-gender world” is an important framework that is used in studying digital spaces from a feminist perspective. Through this cyborg imagery, Haraway makes the case that technology allows women and in fact, all alienated groups to escape the confines of not only the physical, but also of traditional notions of identity. In doing so, she challenges traditional Marxist-feminist notions of gender, equality, and identity and argues for a new feminism that is based on ‘affinities.’ Again, we can stop to consider how to use such a framework to analyse digital spaces. Are there spaces where the anonymity offered by the internet, allows us to transcend our physical reality? For instance, my geographical location does not limit me if I can make friends with someone from the other side of the world. My physical disability may not constrain me from interacting with other people who share my interests. My appearance, economic status, geographical location, language accent, race, caste or religion may not impede me from leaving those social and cultural markers behind and doing the things I want to do. However, whether digital technology is a divider or equaliser is the subject of international discourse.

Activity - 4

Identify an online feminist campaign and analyse its focus and goals. Study how it spreads awareness and in your opinion is it successful?

16.5.2 Online Feminisms and Cyber Ethnography

The term ‘online feminisms’ or ‘networked feminisms’ relates to the use of Internet technologies in innovative ways to address gender issues. Technology tends to be gendered as masculine and this was the case with digital technologies as well.

Partly inspired by Haraway's cyborg, cyber feminists seek to use digital technologies and create online spaces as a tool to empower women.

Cyber ethnography refers to the adaptation of ethnographic methods to study social interaction and community cultures in online spaces. Some of the issues that online feminist activism address are: examining the relationship between women and technology, critiquing gender (and caste/class/race related) inequalities in cyberspace, studying the nature, reason, and response to online misogyny, and designing and building equitable online spaces. Gajjala (2003) takes a postcolonial and subaltern perspective, and insists that it is necessary to locate cyber-feminist discourse within the larger contexts of global power relations.

One important way that online feminisms work is by using social media and digital technologies to not just connect but also politically organise themselves against sexist attitudes, actions, policies, and social structures. Women have created online photo campaigns (like the "I need feminism because" campaign on Tumblr), mobilised to have progressive women elected to office (as in several cities in the USA in 2018), or most dramatically, the Women's March on January 21, 2017 that consisted of over 600 individual marches held around the world and that nearly 10,00,000 people attended in a single location (in Washington DC).

There are several examples of online feminist campaigns in India too. One recent online feminist project is the "Blank Noise" project, as a response to the sexual harassment that women face in public spaces. Since then, the movement has spread to different cities and this group of activists/volunteers use social media and the blogosphere in innovative ways to share stories, grow participation for public events, and gain visibility for their activities and their feminist politics.

The "Why Loiter" movement is also an example of online feminism that draws from a theoretical framework of understanding of how and why women in India are excluded from using public space – in an offline context - freely. This framework, developed by Phadke, Khan & Ranade (2009) has been instrumental in the way we think about the public and private realms and how women are policed when they seek to transgress these boundaries. While originally developed in the context of offline spaces, the framework is helpful in understanding and analysing online spaces as well.

16.5.3 Social Media, Society, and Online Misogyny

In today's world, we can see that patriarchal ideas and misogyny that exists in the offline world, have transferred themselves to digital cultures and online spaces. The many social media platforms – Facebook, Twitter, Youtube, WhatsApp, etc. – are flooded with hate messages against women. This phenomenon is labeled "online misogyny" and has become an issue for study by feminist media researchers.

Studies, over the last five years have shown that cyber stalking, online harassment, trolling, name-calling, and physical threats online have shown that women are subject to such behaviour in a disproportionately greater number than men. In 2016, the UN Spokesperson for Violence against Women highlighted online

violence as a rising concern and a priority. An Amnesty report in 2017 noted that high percentage of women who were targeted experienced negative psychological effects and that online threats often translated to fear of physical safety offline. As we begin to notice the prevalence of patriarchal modes of behaviour in online spaces, we can see how feminist theory becomes useful to understand how even new media technologies may work to exclude and oppress women.

For example, the controversy called Gamergate - where video gamers believed that feminism and progressive ideas were unfavourably influencing video game culture and virtually attacked women in the industry – became a turning point in recognising the seriousness of the issue. Research in this area is ongoing and is addressing such topics as the different kinds of harassment, connection between online and offline harassment, and “toxic masculinity” in digital spaces (Ging & Siaper, 2018).

One of the key concerns in this field of study is that while the online and offline worlds may seem separate and disconnected, research shows that in fact this is not the case. In reality, there is a merging between the two and despite Haraway and others’ utopian notion of post-gender spaces, we are seeing that bias, stereotypes, prejudices, and behaviours all carry over into online spaces as well.

Activity - 5

Choose one instance of online harassment that you personally know or have read about using some of the ideas learnt in this unit. Analyse the issue and record your ideas.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is “networked/online feminisms”?

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.....

.....

2) Why has online misogyny become an issue of great concern?

.....

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.....

16.6 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we discussed how feminist media theory grew out of feminist concerns that women’s issues were not adequately being addressed in media research. We studied how standpoint theory differs from feminist empiricism.

In the next section, we discussed why intersectionality is important in feminist theory and why we should consider it while studying media. We also learned

about the artificial divide of the public/private dichotomy and how it applies to the way women's issues are represented in the media. In addition, we discussed the role of media in constructing gender and identity and saw some examples of how women in "male" spheres of politics and sports are portrayed.

In addition to the politics of representation, we also examined the importance of the processes of media production and consumption.

Finally, we examined the entry of new media technologies into the media landscape and considered the possibilities these technologies could have in democratising media and giving space to marginal voices, including that of women. We explored the phenomenon of online misogyny and the role of online feminisms in mobilising, advertising, and organising information, events and responses to women's issues in both the online and offline worlds.

To sum up, this unit has offered an introduction to feminist media theory and shown some ways it can be used to better analyse media content and contexts.

This is the last unit of the Course Media and Communication Theories. In this course you were exposed to various theoretical perspectives – sociological, psychological, critical and cultural. As you would have seen, each theory has its strengths as well as limitations and some theories have been discussed from more than one perspective. After completing this course, you may go back to some of these theories for a better understanding of the debates, narratives, and the scholarly traditions. We hope, the knowledge gained will enable you to apply some of these theories in your own work and offer scholarly analyses on media texts, audience, technology, gender, culture and a host of other issues.

16.7 FURTHER READINGS

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16.8 KEY TERMS

Intersectionality: the idea that different social identities such as race, class, caste, gender, and sexuality overlap, and contribute to the way women experience discrimination or oppression.

Misogyny: dislike, hatred, prejudice against women.

Performativity: the idea that gender is constructed by the stylised repetition of acts that conform to the idea of a specific gender.

16.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Traditional research models tend to ignore women at all levels of research: from identifying and defining a research question, designing the research project, and in collecting and interpreting data. Feminist media research seeks to make women an active part of the research process – as researchers and as active subjects.
- 2) Feminist empiricism is a viewpoint that believes in adopting scientific enquiry of women's issues. Standpoint theory, on the other hand, insists on research based on women's experiences, from their *own* viewpoints.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) Intersectionality is the idea that we should take into account multiple standpoints of experience as interrelated systems of power (social, cultural, institutional) that are oppressive to marginalised groups can influence a person's experience and perspective.
- 2) Magazines, music videos, soap operas, news coverage.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Smith's concept of "relations of rule" showed how the institutional structures of society – governance, policy, law, and economics – were built and maintained exclusively by men, and specifically organised in such a way as to exclude women from these areas.
- 2) It is easier to study representation in media by getting samples of the media and studying/analysing it. However, studying media consumption requires us to find a sample group and study their viewing habits over a period of time.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) The term refers to the use of Internet technologies in innovative ways to address gender issues. Online campaigns that address women's issues through gathering information, spreading awareness and building participation is now an important and popular use of digital technology.
- 2) Studies have shown that the online harassment of women has grown exponentially over the last decade. Online misogyny has been identified as a real source of oppression of women, and research is showing that there are very real physical dangers and psychological consequences to those involved.

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